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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

9,169 TEMPORARY SHELTERS BUILT IN QUAKE-HIT JAJARKOT

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Jajarkot, Jan. 8

Two months after the November 3 earthquake hit Jajarkot, 9,169 temporary shelters have been built in the district.

The construction of temporary housing was delayed because the earthquake victims failed to get the money allotted by the government for 35,140 beneficiaries for almost two months.

The release of the first instalment of the relief amount was delayed as the local level governments failed to manage the fund in time forcing the victims to continue to live under the tents braving the winter chill.

Although 24,486 beneficiaries have signed the agreement for temporary housing, only 16,841 beneficiaries have collected the first instalment amount from the local governments. As of now, 9,169 temporary shelters have been constructed.

District Disaster Management Committee has distributed the first instalment amount of Rs. 421 million for the local governments of Bheri, Nalagadh and Chhedagadh municipalities, Barekot, Kushe,

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CORONAVIRUS DETECTED AMONG INDIA-RETURNEES

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 8

Coronavirus infection has been detected among the Nepali nationals returning from different cities in India. After the discovery of the new JN. 1 variant in India, COVID-19 testing has been made mandatory at the Nepal-India border points.

According to Dr. Rudra Prasad Marasini, Director of Epidemiology and Disease Control Division, antigen tests are being done at the border points and many Nepalis have been diagnosed with COVID-19.

"There have always been a few COVID-19 cases entering from the border, but due to the concern of the new variant we have asked all the checkpoints to be more vigilant," said Marasini.

Marasini said that people infected with COVID-19 were asked to self-isolate themselves at home. "Every day, hundreds of Nepali return home from various border crossings.

The only suggestion we can give people is to follow COVID-19 protocol and stay vigilant. The information about the people infected with the new

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PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' holding an interaction with the minister and officials of the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation in Singha Durbar, Kathmandu on Monday.

52 aspirants in fray for 19 NA slots

BY RAM PRASAD DAHAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 8

Altogether 52 candidates filed their nominations on Monday for the election of 19 National Assembly members from seven provinces.

Of them, 18 filed their nomination under the women category, five under the Dalit category, eight from disabled and marginalised community categories and 21 from other categories.

They filed their candidacies in respective seven provincial offices of Election Officers to contest the election for the 19 seats of the Upper House slated for January 25. The election commission had allocated time from 10.00 am to 3.00 pm to register their candidacies.

The Election Commission Nepal in its press statement on Monday evening informed that the nominations of candidates were held peacefully in all of its provincial offices. In Koshi Province, five candidates filed their nominations.

Rukmani Koirala of the CPN-UML and Champa Devi Karki of the CPN-Maoist Centre filed their candidacies under the women category. Parshu Ram Adhikair of the UML, Krishna Prasad Sitaula of the Nepali Congress (NC) and Uddav Paudel of Rastriya Prajatantra Party (RPP) filed their nominations under other categories.

In Madhes Province also five candidates filed their nominations. They included Usha Devi Tharuni of the UML and Puja Choudhari of Janata Samajwadi Party, Nepal under the women category, and Kumari Bijeta Jha of UML, Ananda Prasad Dhungana of NC and Ram Shankar Mahaseth of Janamat Party under other category.

Of them, 18 filed their nomination under the women category, five under the Dalit category, eight from disabled and marginalised community categories and 21 from other categories.

In Bagmati Province 15 candidates filed their nominations. Roch Kumari Chaulagai of UML, Bishnu Devi Pudasaini of NC, Bal Kumari Dallakoti of RPP and Krishna Laxmi Duwal of Nepal Majdur Kishan Party (NMKP) filed their candidacy under women category, while Dhurba Raj Bishwokarma of UML, Ghanashyam Rijal of Maoist Centre and Sangita Nepali of NMKP filed candidacy under Dalit category.

Bibek Devkota of UML, Shreekrishna Prasad Adhikari of Maoist Centre and Himaldhar Lal Mul of NMKP filled candidacy under the disabled persons and minority community category. Trilochan Nirmal Paudel of UML, Jeet Jung Basnet of NC, Hem Jung Gurung of RPP and Shreekrishna Maharjan of NMKP filed the candidacy under other category.

In Gandaki Province eight candidates are in the fray. Samjhana Devkota of UML, Manrupa Sharma of Maoist Centre and Goumaya Shrestha of RPP filed their candidacy under the women category while Hemdra Sherchan of UML and Padam Bahadur Pariyar of NC filed candidacy under disabled person and minority community category. Chakra Bahadur Parajuli of UML, Kiran Babu Shrestha of NC and Rom Bahadur Bhandari of RPP filed their candidacy under the other category.

In Lumbini Province seven candidates filed their candidacies. Tulasa Kumari KC of UML, Bishnu Kumari Sapkota of NC and Bijaya Laxmi Singh of RPP filed candidacy under the women category. Jhapendra Bahadur Gharti Chhetri of UML, Jhakku Prasad Subedi of Maoist Centre, Niranjan Kumar Thapa and Bal Govinda Choudhari of Janamat Party filed their candidacy under the other category.

Likewise, six candidates including Bimala Kumari Shahi of UML and Sabitri Malla of CPN (Unified Socialist) filed their candidacy under the women category in Karnali Province. Hikmat B.K. of the UML and Bishnu Bahadur Bishwokarma of the Maoist Centre filed their candidacy under the Dalit category while Dilli Prasad Bhatta of UML and Krishna Bahadur Rokaya of NC filed their candidacy under other category in the Karnali.

Likewise, Sabitra Devi Ghimire of UML and Renu Chand of Maoist Centre under women category, Ram Chandra Joshi of UML and Narayan Dutta Bhatta of NC under disabled person and minority category, Ishwori Prasad Kharel of UML and Bal Dev Bohora of NC under other category filled their candidacy in Sudurpachhim Province. A total of six candidates filed nominations in Sudurpashchim.

EC spokesperson Shaligram Sharma Paudel informed that as per NA election calendar, complaints against candidates can be registered on Tuesday.

Likewise, the nomination letters and complaints will be examined on Wednesday and Thursday and the candidates will be allowed to withdraw their candidacy on Friday and final lists of the candidates will be published on the same day. The candidates will be distributed the election symbols on Saturday.

Let's settle arrears without stopping industries: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 8

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has asked everyone concerned to adopt a measure that enables the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) to collect arrears from the trunk line and dedicated line subscribers while still allowing businesses to operate factories without hindrance.

Holding a discussion with the minister and officials of the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation on Monday, Prime Minister Prachanda said that they needed to heed the instructions given by the Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority and the parliamentary committees and also consult with the Office of the Attorney General.

"Then, we must proceed with collecting the arrears while also keeping the industries open. Please analyse the issue and find a solution," he directed.

Meanwhile, Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet informed that the ministry was working to resolve the dispute regarding trunk and dedicated lines based on facts and prevailing laws.

Stating that industrialists had been given the option of paying their dues in multiple instalments, Minister Basnet believed that the issue would be solved amicably.

Also speaking at the discussion, Kul Man Ghising, managing director of the NEA, said that the Authority wanted to reach a conclusion in consultation with the Electricity Tariff Fixation Commission and shared that it would call for necessary steps towards this end.

The same day, Prime Minister Prachanda also met with officials of the Ministry of Finance and the National Planning Commission (NPC) to talk about revising the structure and process of drafting the policy and programmes and the budget. Specifically, he talked about the policy and programmes and the budget to be made for the next fiscal year 2024/25.

At the meeting, he noted the need for the Finance Ministry to hold extensive discussions with other federal ministries before fixing their budget ceiling. He also felt that the entire ceiling fixation process needed to be reviewed.

"Let us not fix the ceiling based on guesswork. Let's call others and listen to what they have to say," he advised those present at the meeting. "We also need a clear framework on which projects to implement from the centre, which to execute from the provinces and which to give to the local levels. Please make necessary preparations for this," he asked.

He further instructed the Finance Ministry and the NPC to focus on a specific strategic project in each fiscal year and prioritise completing old projects instead of adding new ones.

After listening to the Prime Minister, Minister for Finance Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat promised to follow his instructions and proceed as per the government's decisions.

Dr. Min Bahadur Shrestha, vice-chairman of NPC, told the Prime Minister that the Commission had proposed a calendar that would have the government present its principles and priorities for the fiscal year in February/March, table the policy and programmes in April/May and present the budget on Jestha 15 (this year it falls on May 29).

NEA CUTS OFF POWER SUPPLY TO HULAS STEELS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 8

The Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) has cut the line of one more industry that was receiving power supply from dedicated and trunk lines. According to the NEA, it cut the power supply of Hulas Steels operating in the Bara-Parsa industrial corridor on Monday morning.

The outstanding amount in the industry till mid-December is Rs. 432 million. The Authority has cut the lines of 24 industries with arrears of more than Rs. 50 million.

Out of this, Himal Steel has paid the outstanding amount in installments and after paying the first installment, the Authority has reconnected the line.

According to the Authority, 61 industries have to pay Rs. 22.24 billion in arrears.

Earlier, the electricity supply of Baba Jute Mills, Nigale Cement, Triveni Synthetic Yarn Industries, Himal Iron and Steel, Jagdamba Enterprises, Hama Iron and Everest Paper Mills had been disconnected by the NEA.

Similarly, electricity supply of Cosmos Cement, Shubhashree Agni Cement, Jagdamba Synthetic, Gharana Foods, Siddhartha PET Plast, Butwal Cement, Narayani Ispat, Jagadamba Steels, Reliance Spinning Mills, Ghorahi Cement and Arghakhanchi Cement had been cut.

The NEA has started to cut electricity supply of industries having electricity arrears since December 22, 2023.

The private sector requested the government to immediately connect the electricity of those industries whose line has been cut citing that there are arrears without actual base and proof or non-payment of arrears.

The NEA had made it clear that it has a strategy to cut power supply lines of industries that do not pay electricity arrears under the dedicated feeders and trunk lines.

RSS should serve as bridge between state, citizens: Minister Sharma



RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 8

Minister for Communications and Information Technology, Rekha Sharma, has said the State-owned media should serve as a means of establishing a vital link between the state and the citizens.

In an event marking the launch of the RSS news service in Awadhi language on Monday, Minister Sharma expressed the view that the state-owned media should function as a conduit, conveying government activities to the public and bringing citizens' concerns to the attention of the government.

During the inauguration ceremony, the Minister stressed that the media houses were expected to inform the government about the challenges, expectations, and needs of the people while at the same time making citizens aware of the positive initiatives undertaken by the government.

The inclusion of the Awadhi language in the RSS news bulletin will be a great support to those mother tongue-based media when they face challenges to perform effectively amidst the limitations of resources, the Minister said.

She announced that incorporating the Awadhi language into the RSS news bulletin was itself the assimilation of the spirit of federalism and inclusion enshrined by the Constitution.

"It is the responsibility of the government to implement federalism and inclusion, and the expansion of the RSS service in the Awadhi language should

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Joy at receiving citizenship in mother's name

BY TILACHAN PANDEY
Tamghas, Jan. 8

For years, Raj Kumar Pariyar, 23, of Dhurkot Rural Municipality-7, Gulmi, was denied citizenship because his father could not be identified. But on Monday, he finally received a citizenship certificate in the name of his mother.

He was so happy that he could barely speak. He hoped that the citizenship would open new doors for him. "The certificate may give me access to opportunities that I had so far been deprived of," he said expectantly.

Pariyar can drive a jeep. But a lack of citizenship had prevented him from obtaining a driving licence. "I had not even been able to purchase a SIM card for my mobile," he recalled the ordeals he had faced because of the lack of the certificate. "May all that change now!" he exclaimed.

Meanwhile, his mother, 53-year-old Gyani Pariyar, hoped that Raj Kumar receiving the citizenship certificate would allow her other two sons to receive citizenship certificates as well.



PHOTO: TILACHAN PANDEY/TRN

Raj Kumar Pariyar of Dhurkot Rural Municipality-7 in Gulmi receiving a citizenship certificate in the name of his mother.

Gyani is speech-impaired and her sons were born from strangers she cannot identify. This made them unable to obtain citizenship until the government amended the Citizenship Act last year.

Assistant Chief District Officer of Gulmi Hari Prasad Gaire informed that five people had received citizenship certificates in the name of their mothers in the district since the Citizenship Act was amended on May 31, 2023, and its corresponding regulation was amended on September 21.

As per the District Administration Office (DAO), those wishing to apply for citizenship in their mother's name must furnish their mother's citizenship or death certificate if she has passed away, three-generation details of their mother's family, their birth certificate under the mother's name, official certificate of relationship and necessary recommendations from the ward office. After examining these documents, the DAO may ask to police to conduct further investigations into the applicant if any of the documents look suspicious or are missing.

If everything is found to be in order, then the Administration will grant the applicant a citizenship certificate in their mother's name.

Praising the DAO and the government, Padam Prasad Pandey, chairman of Gulmi's Civil Society, emphasised everyone who is forced to be stateless despite being born to Nepali mothers should be provided with citizenship certificates.

"Only they know the pain their situation causes," he said, emphasising the need to effectively inform everyone about the amendments and their right to receive citizenship in their mother's name.

Paddy production touches record level of 5.7M tonnes

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 8



FILE PHOTO/TRN

Farmers in Gundu, Bhaktapur were busy on paddy harvesting. (

Paddy production has increased to 5.724 million tonnes, the highest yield in Nepal, this year. According to the report published by the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock and Development, the paddy output totalled 5.724 million tonnes that is 268,000 tonnes higher than last year's harvest.

About 5.486 million tonnes of paddy was produced in the last fiscal year 2022/23. Earlier, Nepal had grown 5.621 million tonnes of rice in the fiscal year 2020/21. However, the yield had fallen to 5.13 million tonnes in the last fiscal year 2021/22. Similarly, about 5.55 million tonnes of paddy was produced in the fiscal year 2019/20.

According to the Ministry, the production of rice has increased by 4.33 per cent this year as compared to last year's production. It is to be noted that paddy was planted in less area this year than the last year.

In the year 2022/23, paddy plantation was done in 1,447,789 hectares while plantation was done in 1,438,989 hectares of land this year.

According to spokesperson of the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development Sabnam Shivakoti Aryal, there has been a significant increase in paddy production even though there was plantation in 8,800 hectares less compared to the last year.

The Ministry has released paddy production data after analysing the production data with the help of the data collected from the districts by the Ministry of Agriculture of the seven provinces and the satellite email provided by ICIMOD.

According to the Ministry, the quantity of paddy production has been calculated based on the area of paddy planted in Tarai Madhes and the percentage of paddy plantation rate in the current fiscal year.

The productivity of rice has increased by 4.97 per cent to 3.98 tons per hectare in the current fiscal year as compared to the previous year, she said.

Compared to the average productivity of the last four years, productivity has increased by 6.92 per cent in the current fiscal year, the ministry said.

Shivakoti said that the increase in rice production is due to the availability of advanced seeds and reduction in the incidence of diseases and pests, reduction in the negative effects of floods and landslides on rice crops, and the availability of fertilisers.

Highest yield in Koshi Province

According to the Ministry, the maximum amount of paddy has been grown in Koshi Province out of the seven provinces. About 1.435 million tonnes of paddy has been grown in the province this year.

Similarly, around 1.33 million tonnes of paddy has been produced in Madhes Province, 504,344 tonnes in Bagmati, 391,624 tonnes in Gandaki, 1.31 million tonnes in Lumbini, 145,063 tonnes in Karnali and 591,124 tonnes in Sudurpashchim Province.

In terms of productivity also, the paddy production yield is highest in Koshi Province while the production was lowest in Karnali Province.

The production yield stood at 4.43 tonnes per hectare in Koshi Province and 3.49 tonnes per hectare in Madhes Province.

Production yield stood at 3.91 tonnes per hectare in Bagmati Province, 3.84 tonnes per hectare in Gandaki Province, 4.33 tonnes per hectare in Lumbini Province and 3.46 tonnes per hectare in Karnali and 3.83 tonnes per hectare in Sudurpashchim Province.

In terms of production and productivity growth compared to last year, Lumbini Province has seen the highest growth in the current fiscal year, while Madhes Province has achieved negative growth.

At the time of paddy plantation, there was not enough rainfall in Tarai Madhes, planting was done very late and there was a lack of rainwater even after planting, which has led to a reduction in paddy in Madhes compared to other provinces, said the Ministry.

DOT RELEASES NAMES OF CLIMBERS YET TO RECEIVE SUMMIT CERTIFICATES

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 8

The Department of Tourism (DoT) has released the names of 48 climbers from three agencies who have not yet received summit certificates. Issuing a public notice last week, the DoT stated that the four dozen mountaineers received permission to climb Mount Everest and other mountains in the country on various dates.

But, due to the death or disappearance of their team leader, them returning to their countries, or loss of contact, the Department has not been briefed on their climb and, as a result, they have not received summit certificates. Their garbage deposit has also not been refunded.

Saying that it needs to take a decision on these files, the Department has also given individuals and entities 15 days' time to submit any complaints, grievances or disputes relating to the climbers' ascents. They must also present evidence to support their application.

According to the DoT, 14 people who scaled Mount Everest from the agency Seven Summit Treks in 2018, 13 people who climbed the mountain from the company Himalayan Ski Trek in 2019 and one individual from Peak Promotion Pvt. Ltd. who also reached the top of the peak in the same year have not taken summit certificates.

Similarly, a dozen climbers who climbed Makalu in 2018 and eight climbers who summitted Dhaulagiri in 2022 also have not got their certificates. Both these teams were managed by the Seven Summit Treks.

Service-recipients face inconvenience due to delay in repairing charging station

RSS
Bharatpur, Jan. 8

Service-recipients are deprived of service as the charging station based at Muglin Bazaar, Ichhakamana rural municipality-5, Chitwan, remains dysfunctional nearly for two months.

It is said that the charging nozzle of the charging station has broken and two DC chargers are dysfunctional less than a year since the station was installed. Only one AC charger is functioning at present. It takes long time to charge vehicles only from the AC charger, it is said.

Dhruba Gurung of Gorkha who came to charge his car complained that service-seekers including himself have been facing problem as the charging station here still remains unrepaired. As he said, one has to wait for hours on end charging vehicles using AC charger. He said his vehicle is charged only six per cent in 20 minutes.

"The vehicle used to be fully charged in one hour when the charging station was functioning. Now, one has to wait for 2-3 hours to fully charge the car," he expressed his dismay.

He complained that although the government has emphasized on using electric vehicles, it has not paid attention to constructing additional charging stations and repairing the dysfunctional ones in time.

According to him, people have to wait in queue for many hours to charge their vehicles since there are not enough charging stations.

Shiva Adhikari, project manager of Digo, the company which is responsible for constructing the charging station, said that the problem is due to the broken charging nozzle and they have already ordered for the required spares that need to be changed. He added that the equipment would be arriving in a day or two. He said the repairing works would be carried out in a day or two by dispatching a technical team.

Adhikari said 62 charging stations have been installed throughout the country through the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA). He stated problems have been detected in 20 of them.

CNI demands new legislature for country's speedy development

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 8

The Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) has suggested the government scrap, amend and formulate a few acts and regulations for the industrial, economic and social development of the nation.

The CNI has requested the government to amend 28 laws, scrap five and introduce three new ones.

The Confederation, which has been raising issues in various forums for a long time about the legal confusion and its effects, has made a formal proposal to the government regarding the amendment, scrapping and formulation of 36 laws and regulations.

The book prepared by the Confederation after discussion with the experts of the related field was made public on Monday and submitted to the government as well.

The CNI has suggested scrapping five laws, including Act Restricting Investment Abroad, 2021 BS, Compensation Act, 2019 BS, Black-marketing and Some Other Social Offenses and Punishment Act, 2032 BS, Nepal Agency Act, 2014 BS and Patent, Design and Trade Mark Act, 2022 BS.

Similarly, the CNI has suggested to amend 28 laws, including Foreign Investment and Technology Transfer Act, 2075 BS, Foreign Investment and Technology Transfer Regulation, 2075 BS, Public-Private Partnership and Investment Act 2075 BS, Industrial Enterprises Act 2076 BS, Company Act 2063 BS, Labour Act, 2074 BS and Income Act, 2058 BS.

Similarly, the CNI has requested to amend Special Economic Zone Act, 2075 BS, Industrial Enterprises Rules, 2078 BS, Electricity Act 2049 BS, Public Procurement Act, 2063 BS, Forest Act, 2076 BS, Bonus Rules, 2039 BS and Mines and Minerals Act, 2042 BS.

In accordance with Section 10A of the Foreign Exchange Regulation Act, Nepal Rastra Bank's Public Information, Patent Design and Trademark Act and Payment Protection Act have been suggested, the CNI said.

Organising a press conference, President of CNI Rajesh Agrawal said that the CNI has submitted a report to the Prime Minister and the Chief Secretary with the issues that need to be addressed in the laws for overall economic development of the nation.

> The Confederation, which has been raising issues in various forums for a long time about the legal confusion and its effects, has made a formal proposal to the government regarding the amendment, scrapping and formulation of 36 laws and regulations.

He said that reforms in the laws would make the economy prosperous and economic activities would increase.

He informed that Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal "Prachanda" has also promised to revise and improve the laws as per the suggestion provided by the CNI.

In order to achieve the goal of rapid economic growth, the Confederation believes that it is necessary to create an investment environment and industrialise at the same pace.

"A favouruable legal system plays an important role in attracting investment and industrial development.

All sectors have realised the need to follow a system that facilitates the aspiration of rapid economic prosperity by making clear legal provisions to prevent the lack of policy stability," he said.

Stating that the government will take the recommendations of the Confederation to support the overall economic development and give special priority to reforming the existing laws and formulating new laws, Agrawal said that the government should amend these laws before the investment conference to be held in coming March.

German farmes protest against plan to scrap diesel tax

AP
Berlin, Jan. 8



PHOTO: AP

Farmers demonstrated with their tractors in front of the state parliament in Kiel, Germany to scrap tax breaks on diesel used in agriculture.

Farmers blocked highway access roads in parts of Germany Monday and snarled traffic elsewhere with their tractors, launching a week of protests against a government plan to scrap tax breaks on diesel used in agriculture.

Chancellor Olaf Scholz's unpopular three-party coalition infuriated farmers last month by drawing up plans to abolish a car tax exemption for farming vehicles and the diesel tax breaks. The proposals were part of a package to fill a 17-billion-euro ($18.6-billion) hole in the 2024 budget.

The government on Thursday climbed down partially, saying that the car tax exemption would be retained and the cuts in the diesel tax breaks would be staggered over three years. But the German Farmers' Association said it was still insisting on the plans being reversed fully and would go ahead with a "week of action" starting Monday.

In some areas, farmers used tractors to block entry roads to highways early Monday.

There was disruption due to convoys of tractors in and around some cities, too. Production at a Volkswagen auto plant in Emden in northwestern Germany was stopped because access roads were blocked, preventing employees from getting to work, German news agency dpa reported.

Among demonstrations across the country, several hundred tractors and other vehicles gathered in front of the Brandenburg Gate in Berlin.

The protests are under scrutiny after a group of farmers on Thursday prevented Vice Chancellor Robert Habeck from disembarking a ferry in a small North Sea port as he returned from a personal trip to an offshore island.

That incident drew condemnation from government and opposition figures and the farmers association. Authorities have warned that far-right groups and others could try to capitalize on the protests.

Farmers association chairman Joachim Rukwied told RBB Inforadio Monday that "we will ensure we are not infiltrated" by such groups.

Of the government's partial climbdown, Rukwied said: "This is absolutely insufficient.

We can't carry this additional tax burden." Scholz's spokesperson, Steffen Hebestreit, defended the government's actions.

"There is no consideration inside the government of changing anything else about this," he said.

The budget revamp that included the disputed cuts was required after Germany's highest court annulled an earlier decision to repurpose 60 billion euros (almost $66 billion) originally meant to cushion the fallout from the COVID-19 pandemic for measures to help combat climate change and modernize the country.

The maneuver fell afoul of Germany's strict self-imposed limits on running up debt.

On top of potential disruption caused by the farmers' protests, travelers in Germany face a nearly three-day strike later this week by a union representing many of the country's train drivers, which is stepping up its action against state-owned railway operator Deutsche Bahn in an unrelated dispute over working hours and pay.

The GDL union is calling on its members to walk out from 2 a.m. Wednesday until 6 p.m. Friday.

US lunar lander rockets toward moon with commercial deliveries

AP
Cape Canaveral, Fla. Jan. 8

The first U.S. lunar lander in more than 50 years rocketed toward the moon Monday, launching private companies on a space race to make deliveries for NASA and other customers.

Astrobotic Technology's lander caught a ride on a brand new rocket, United Launch Alliance's Vulcan. The Vulcan streaked through the Florida predawn sky, putting the spacecraft on a roundabout route to the moon that should culminate with an attempted landing on Feb. 23.

"So, so, so excited. We are on our way to the moon!" Astrobotic chief executive John Thornton said. The Pittsburgh company aims to be the first private business to successfully land on the moon, something only four countries have accomplished. But a Houston company also has a lander ready to fly, and could beat it to the lunar surface, taking a more direct path.

"First to launch. First to land is TBD," to be determined, Thornton noted. NASA gave the two companies millions to build and fly their own lunar landers. The space agency wants the privately owned landers to scope out the place before astronauts arrive while delivering NASA tech and science experiments as well as odds and ends for other customers. Astrobotic's contract for the Peregrine lander: $108 million.

The last time the U.S. launched a moon-landing mission was in December 1972. Apollo 17's Gene Cernan and Harrison Schmitt became the 11th and 12th men to walk on the moon, closing out an era that has remained NASA's pinnacle.

The space agency's new Artemis program — named after the twin sister of Apollo in Greek mythology — looks to return astronauts to the moon's surface within the next few years. First will be a lunar fly-around with four astronauts, possibly before the end of the year.

Highlighting Monday's moonshot was the long-delayed initial test flight of the Vulcan rocket from Cape Canaveral Space Force Station.

Rs. 5,000 fine decided for abandoning cattle loose



PHOTO:BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL/TRN

Locals of the Bahundangi area in Mechinagar Municipality, Jhapa, are chasing away stray cattle that enter their settlement crossing the Indian border.

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Jan. 8

Locals of the Bahundangi area in Mechinagar Municipality, Jhapa, are fed up with Indian wild elephants and stray cattle that enter their settlement crossing the border.

Arjun Karki, the Ward Chairman of Mechinagar-4, reported that wild elephants and cattle from India have caused significant damage to crops. In the border area towards India side, there is a dense forest where Indian residents release their cattle to graze but these cattle venture directly onto the farms of Nepali farmers, and cause harm to the crops. The farmers have asked the local authorities numerous times to take measures to check the entry of Indian cattle. According to Karki, they have imposed a fine of up to Rs. 5000 against those who abandon their cattle in the Nepali land.

Karki also said that, "The distressed farmers from Nepali side brought more than 20 stray cattle coming from India and staged a sit-in at the ward office, and in response a decision was made to impose fines to control the situation."

"The ward office has also informed the farmers of the border area about the fine that can be imposed on the stray cattle that ravages the farms of Nepali residents. Karki informed them that such quadrupeds would be kept under control and would be released only after the owner pays the fine" said karki.

"It is difficult to control wild elephants entering Nepal but stray quadrupeds can be controlled if the authority show willpower," said Karki.

Arjun Rana, a local said, "Some farmers prefer keeping their fields barren owing to the fear of such cattle. Farmers often complain that they have to guard their fields from elephants and animals to protect their harvest."

Laws should be enacted to promote good governance

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 8

Karnali Province Chief Minister Raj Kumar Sharma has said that necessary laws should be made, enacted and amended to promote good governance as the country has become a federal republic.

Issuing a press statement on Sunday evening, the Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) informed that a provincial-level interaction on corruption prevention and promotion of good governance concluded in Birendranagar of Karnali Province and Dang of Lumbini Province.

Speaking at the interaction held in Karnali, Chief Minister Sharma said that local representatives and government employees held an important role in good governance. He said that the province faced challenges in implementing projects and programmes due to the lack of employees and such interactions would facilitate the smooth functioning of the provincial government.

Chief Secretary of Karnali Province Chuda Mani Poudel said that civil servants should perform their duties effectively and transparently to control corruption.

He said that employees should not be afraid upon receiving complaints against them and should work adhering to the laws.

On the occasion, CIAA Secretary Rameshwor Dangal said that public bodies should choose and implement programmes and projects that are result-oriented.

> Speaking at the interaction held in Karnali, Chief Minister Sharma said that local representatives and government employees held an important role in good governance.

He said that all bodies should follow the recommendations repeatedly made by the CIAA through its annual reports and other occasions.

Karnali Province's Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Urban Development Mangal Bahadur Shahi, Minister for Economic Affairs and Planning Bed Raj Singh Minister for Land Management, Agriculture and Cooperatives Bhim Prakash Sharma, Minister of Internal Affairs and Law, Krishna Bahadur GC, Chief of Surkhet CIAA office Madhav Prasad Pokhrel and others were present in the programme.

Meanwhile, in the interaction in Dang, Lumbini Province Chief Minister Dilli Bahadur Chaudhary assured that the government led by him would not misuse the budget. He stressed the implementation of an effective monitoring system to control corruption in development projects.

Lumbini Province Chief Secretary Radhika Aryal committed to enhancing governance and performance in the overall administration of the province.

Prem Kumar Rai, CIAA Chief Commissioner, said that the complaints submitted to the CIAA would be investigated and settled on the basis of facts and evidence.

He said that issues related to the provincial policy-making decision and administrative policy-making decisions should be settled at the provincial level and administrative level respectively instead of taking them to the Council of the Ministers.

Stating that the Consumer Committee should be assigned work according to their capability, he stressed the need for transparency and accountability in the use of machinery and equipment, guarantee/deposit, price escalation in bills, and the official use of the constructed structure along with proper maintenance and care. He said study, budgeting and planning must be carried out before implementing development projects.

Additionally, he stressed the importance of ensuring transparency in grant distribution, creating necessary standards and allocating grants based on measurable criteria.

Lumbini Province's Minister for Finance Dhan Bahadur Maski, Health Minister Raju Khanal, Home Minister Santosh Kumar Pandey, Urban Development Minister Krishna KC, Agriculture and Land Management Minister Bhandari Lal Ahir, Social Development Minister Chandrakesh Gupta and others were present at the programme.

Nepal's largest cave remains neglected

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Tansen, Jan. 8

Shiddha Gufa the largest cave in Nepal and second largest cave in South Asia, is a limestone cave, about 50 metres high and 430 metres deep, but this cave has remained in shadow for a long time.

Due to a lack of publicity, the Siddha Cave in Tansen-12 has remained unknown to the outer world.

Even the tourists who visit Rani Mahal doesn't bother Siddha Gufa, although it lies on the way to Rani Mahal.

According to Buddha Bahadur Thapa, a local of Tansen-12, around 300 tourists visit Rani Mahal daily, but in lack of information they hardly visit this beautiful cave.

He further said, "If the cave is promoted, tourists coming to visit Rani Mahal and Tansen will also observe the cave."

There are stones of different shapes inside the cave. Such natural structures can be an attraction to the tourists.

The cave can attract both domestic and foreign tourists but it is not promoted as much as it should have been, said Rajiv Kumar Shah of Nepal Tours and Travel of Palpa.

He said one could reach Siddha Cave on a 20-minute walk from the way to Rani Mahal. According to the locals, the cave was discovered in 1996. Locals are working to make the cave systematic and safe.

The entry point of the cave was made safe and an electric light have been installed inside the cave, said Tankanath Ghimire, president of the Cave Management Committee.

Locals are working to make cave systematic but no concerned bodies have paid attention to promote this exquisite cave.

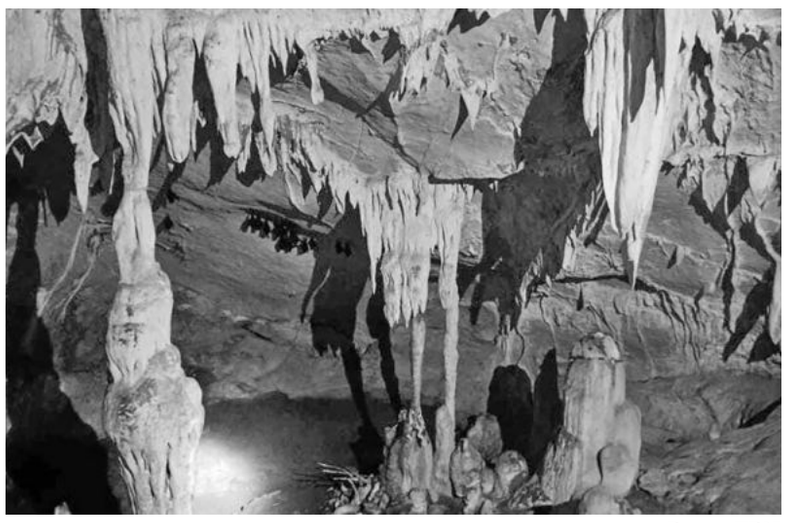


PHOTO: TRN

The Shiddha Gufa, the largest cave in Nepal and second largest cave in South Asia, remains in neglected state in Tansen, Palpa.

TRN journos receive Int'l Peace Prize

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Nepalgunj, Jan. 8

Four journalists from Banke, including The Rising Nepal's Nepalgunj correspondent Siraj Khan and Banke correspondent Govinda Sharma, have received the International Peace Prize.

They were awarded the prize at the international conference on war, peace and human rights organised by the SAARC Journalist Forum and the media organisation Manav Adhikar Today in Vaishali, Bihar, India.

The conference was held for two days and was attended by over 200 media persons and human rights activists from Nepal, India, Bangladesh and Mauritius.



PHOTO: TRN

Govinda Sharma and Siraj Khan receiving the International Peace Prize.

National meet of freed Harawacharawas to be held in Janakpur on Feb 24-25

RSS
Janakpurdham, Jan. 8

The national convention of the National Harawacharawa, destitute, Rights Forum (NHRF) is scheduled for February 24 and 25 in Janakpurdham.

According to Forum general-secretary Lagendra, they are preparing for the national convention which will be held at the local Bahra Bigha Rangabhumi ground.

He said the Forum had already held the district-level conventions in all eight districts of the Madhes Province between October 14, 2023 and January 5, 2024.

Similarly, the Forum organised the municipality-level convention in over 60 local levels with predominantly Harawacharawa populations before the district conventions, Forum leader and Dhanusha district president Rajdev Mukhiya said. "Now we have geared up for the national convention after conducting the local and district-level conventions.

Hundreds of Harawacharawas, and representatives and observers of national and international development partner organisations will be attending the national convention," he added.

The Harawacharawas had been waging a movement for emancipation from the Harawacharawa practice, a kind of bonded labour system, with the Rastriya Dalit Network (RDN)'s support, said Hukum Bahadur Sarki, executive director of RDN which has been supporting the Harawacharawa's campaign. The government freed the Harawacharawas from the exploitative practice on July 18, 2022.

Australian man marks birthday with school kids in Nepal

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Birtamod, Jan. 8

Rabin Poudel, who has been living in Australia, celebrated his 28th birthday with the children of Kankai Child Education Center of Tribeni Tole in Kankai Municiplaity-4, when he was in Nepal.

Poudel, who reached the Child Education Centre with his parents, cut down the extra expenses on the birthday and provided the necessary educational materials like copies, pencils and other materials to the children.

Meena Basnet, the school's principal, said that the financial condition of most of the children's parents is weak and they have been maintaining their livelihood by collecting sand and pebbles in the Kankai River Locals said that helping students from poor families with the expenses of birthdays was a good deed.

Rabin has committed to do something for the Child Education Centre when he comes to Nepal in the coming days.



PHOTO: TRN

Rabin Poudel celebrating his 28th birthday with the children of Kankai Child Education Center of Tribeni Tole in Kankai Municiplaity-4 in Birtamod, Jhapa.

NEWS BRIEF

Two arrested with 216 kg marijuana

Inaruwa: Police have arrested two alleged hashish smugglers from Koshi Rural Municipality in Sunsari district.

Acting upon a tip-off, a joint police team deployed from Shriparibdi and the temporary police post of Koshi detained them from Kumyahi of Koshi Rural Municipality-2 on Monday morning.

Deputy Superintendent of Police Nabin Krishna Bhandari said that the police seized 216.45 kilograms of marijuana from smugglers Sagir Miya, 34, of Koshi Rural Municipality-6 and Indian citizen Arbind Kumar of Sapaul district, India.

IGP Aryal observes Hilsa border outposts

Humla: Inspector General of the Armed Police Force Nepal Raju Aryal has inspected the border outposts on the Hilsa border point between Nepal and China.

Four years after the establishment of the BoP in Hilsa, the border posts have been monitored by a high-ranking police officer.

Gunjan Pratap Malla, Deputy Superintendent of Police and chief of the No. 44 Company, was also with Armed Police Force Inspector General Aryal during the monitoring of the border posts of Hilsa on Monday.

During the process, IGP Aryal inspected the border pillars No. 9 and 10 and instructed the security personnel deputed at the station to work with high morale.

(TRN)

Krishi Samagri Company Limited
Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu

Invitation For Electronic Bids

For the supply and delivery of Chemical Fertilizer
Contract Identification No. : KSCL/U/ICB-160/080/081
(Published Date : JANUARY 9, 2024)

1. Krishi Samagri Company Limited (KSCL), Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu, Nepal has annual program **towards the cost for the procurement of Supply and Delivery of Chemical** Fertilizer, Contract **Identification No: KSCL/U/ICB-160/080/081 and intends to apply part of** the funds to cover eligible payments under the contract. Bidding is open to all eligible Bidders from all countries.
2. Krishi Samagri Company Limited (KSCL), Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu, Nepal invites electronic bids from **eligible bidders for the procurement of Supply and Delivery of Chemical** Fertilizer as mentioned below, ***under International competitive bidding* – Single Stage Two Envelope** ***procedures specified in Public Procurement Act and Regulations.*** The fertilizer must be delivered at CIP Nepal basis (Biratnagar, Birgunj and Bhairahawa KSCL warehouses) with insurance up to the final destination as mentioned in the bid document.

Invitation for Bid No	Commodity	Quantity	Cost of the bid document (NRs)	Required bid Security (USD)
KSCL/U/ICB-160/080/081	UREA 46-0-0	30,000±2% MT	20,000.00	3,24,000.00

3. Under the Single Stage, Two Envelope Procedure, Bidders are required to submit simultaneously two separate sealed envelopes, one containing (i) the Technical Bid and the other (ii) the Price Bid, both in turn enclosed in one sealed envelope as per the provision of ITB 23 of the Bidding Document.
4. Eligible **Bidders may obtain further information and inspect the bidding documents at the office** of **Krishi Samagri Company Limited (KSCL), Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu, Nepal** (Tel: 977-01- 5274819, Email: aicl.nepal@gmail.com) **or may visit KSCL's website: http://kscl.gov.np**
5. A **complete** *set* of Bidding Documents may be downloaded from PPMO's e-GP system www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp. Bidders, submitting their bid electronically should deposit the cost of bidding document as mentioned above in the account as specified below. **Purchased bid** document will be valid only for specified Principal Supplier.
Information to deposit the cost of bidding document in Bank :
Name of Office : Krishi Samagri Company Limited (KSCL), Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu.
Current Account of Nepal Investment Mega Bank Ltd. Kalimati with account No. 01701030001922.
6. Pre-bid meeting shall be held at **Krishi Samagri Company Limited (KSCL), Head Office,** Kuleshwor, Kathmandu, Nepal **at 14:00 hours, February 7, 2023.**
7. Electrornic **bids must be submitted to the office Krishi Samagri Company Limited (KSCL),** Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu through **PPMO's e-GP system www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp** on or before 13:00 hours on FEBRUARY 23, 2024. Bids **or any part thereof received after this** deadline will be rejected.
8. The **bids will be opened in the presence of Bidders' representatives who choose to attend** at 14:00 hours on FEBRUARY 23, 2024 at the office of **Krishi Samagri Company Limited** (KSCL), Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu. **Bids must be valid for a minimum period of 21** days from the date of bid opening and must be accompanied by scanned copy of the bid security in pdf format, amounting as mentioned above, which shall be valid for 120 days **from the date** of opening of **the bid (i.e. June 21, 2024)**
9. If the **last date of purchasing and/or submission falls on a government holiday, then the next** working day shall be considered as the last date. In such case the validity period of the bid security shall remain the same as specified for the original last date of bid submission.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Invincibility lies in the defence; the possibility of victory in the attack.
- Sun Tzu

EDITORIAL

Banke's Eco-tourism Plan

Nepal is blessed to have a significant portion of its land covered with forests – at 44 per cent and counting. That we've succeeded in significantly growing this green cover amid alarming levels of deforestation in many parts of the world has brought an abiding sense of pride to all Nepalis. In a rapidly warming world where extreme weather events – like heat waves – have become increasingly common and dangerously frequent, forests are hailed as one of the most effective solutions to stop climate change and one of the best defenses against its devastating impacts. And without our protected areas in the forms of national parks and wildlife reserves, which house a variety of forests alongside untold number of wildlife and birds, this wouldn't have happened.

Today the country has 20 such protected areas, two of which have been featured in the list of natural world heritage sites – Sagarmatha National Park and Chitwan National Park (CNP) – for many decades now. Our decision to open up the Banke National Park (BaNP) in 2010 added the newest feather in the cap of our conservation efforts, doubling down on our commitment to go to any length to preserve and promote our rich biodiversity and natural ecology. Established specially for the conservation of endangered tiger, a wildlife tourist magnet, the park is also home to 124 plants, 34 mammals, over 300 birds, 24 reptiles, seven amphibians and 58 fish species. Many of these species are globally rare. Spanning across the Tarai, Bhawar and Chure regions, encompassing all three types of climates and vegetation, the park has now charted plans to attract visitors.

The fact that one gets an opportunity to closely observe all these in one area can enthuse visitors of all stripes. Tapping into this potential is the need of the hour. To that end, plans have been laid out to improve tourism infrastructure and facilities. Homestays have sprung up to cater to tourists keen to learn the food, culture, lifestyle, attire, and more of the ethnic communities inhabiting the area. Construction of infrastructure to facilitate boating as well as rafting in the Rapti River, which meander through the park, jungle safari, elephant ride, walking along forest trails, viewing sunset, among others, have been in the works. To support these tourism initiatives, various skill-based training programmes have also been carried out for the locals.

We believe the park will succeed in its endeavour to bring in more and more tourists. One reason is that the culture of venturing out to experience wonders of nature is rapidly gaining ground among Nepalis, like the people in the rest of the world. The foreign tourists visiting the country is growing in number, with the 2023 figure showing signs of revival in the tourism sector. However, we must be cautious not to get overwhelmed by the sheer number of arriving tourists in a sensitive area like national park. We need to learn from Bhutan and Venice where they have put control measures on visitor pressure. Unwavering focus on sustainable tourism while also keeping the delicate ecosystem underpinned by rivers, mountains, forests, biodiversity and others intact must be of overriding importance. The threat of rampant activities needs to be kept at bay. We must target quality tourism over quantity as well as high-value tourists who contribute to our economy and conservation in a meaningful way.

Secrets Of Charisma

RONALD E. RIGGIO

The roots of charisma are religious. Charisma means the divine gift of grace, and there are notions of charisma in Christian religion. Secular ideas of charisma are best represented by German sociologist, Max Weber, who discussed charismatic authority. According to Weber, certain individuals possess extraordinary qualities that seem to captivate others. As a result, that charismatic individual is seen as a leader and attracts devoted followers. This led to a long line of research on charismatic leadership, including theories by House and Conger and colleagues. Beyond charismatic leadership, however, here is a focus on the qualities that make a person charismatic, regardless of whether or not they are a leader.

Charisma is not one thing. Research suggests that it's a composite of different qualities possessed by certain individuals that helps draw attention to them, and makes them attractive to others. Yet, charismatic influence is a relationship-based phenomenon. These dimensions of charisma can be put into five categories.

Our earliest research on charisma centered on people who were naturally and spontaneously emotionally expressive. We found that emotionally expressive people were better liked in initial encounters, including salespersons, public speakers, and actors. Much of the research that has attempted to train people to become more charismatic has focused on becoming more emotionally expressive in their facial expressions, tone of voice, and gesturing. Some people may have a natural emotional expressiveness that is advantageous and predisposes them to be seen as more charismatic. We have found, however, that expressiveness needs to be controlled and regulated to be seen as truly charismatic.

Additional lines of research have looked at the speech of charismatic individuals, focusing on charismatic leaders—Martin Luther King Jr., John F. Kennedy, Bill Clinton, and other charismatic US leaders. They all were eloquent speakers, and this verbal ability is also important to one being perceived as charismatic. For example, in analysing the speeches of US Presidents, those who were rated as more charismatic included more metaphors in their speeches. Moreover, the speech pattern is also important. More charismatic individuals are more verbally fluent, with fewer speech disturbances.

While being expressive and verbally articulate will lead to initial impressions of charisma, truly charismatic individuals connect with others. People who interacted with charismatic presidents JFK and Bill Clinton said that they made you feel like "you were the only person in the room." Our research shows that charismatic persons can easily pick up on the emotions of others and respond to them. Thus, interacting with a truly charismatic individual feels like a rewarding encounter.

This is the term that we use to describe the poise and social confidence that charismatic persons possess. Charismatic individuals understand the dynamics of social situations and can relate to, and fit in with, a wide variety of different people. A prototype of savoir-faire is a fictional character, James Bond, who is always calm, cool, collected, and in charge, in any situation.

Regardless of the personal charismatic qualities one possesses, charisma and charismatic influence is a relationship. As we learn from research on charismatic leadership, only persons who are favorable towards the leader will be enthralled by the leader's charisma. For example, Democrats are more likely than Republicans to say that President Obama is charismatic, while Republicans, are more likely to judge President Trump as having charisma. While persons possessing the elements of charisma—emotional expressiveness, verbal and relationship skills, poise, and self-confidence—are more likely to be seen as charismatic, the true power of charisma comes down to a social relationship.

- Psychology Today

National Assembly Election

Partnership Among Ruling Alliance



Narayan Upadhyay

Given that every candidate put forward by the ruling coalition partners is expected to win the January 25 National Assembly elections, which are being held to elect 19 members, it is apparent that the close collaboration among ruling parties is still going strong. With a majority in both provincial assemblies and local units, the ruling alliance partners will have no trouble in electing their candidates, who will be chosen by the votes of 1498 chiefs and deputies from local units and 549 members of provincial assemblies.

According to reports, the Nepali Congress will send its ten members, the Maoist Centre will elect six, the Janata Samajwadi Party one and the Unified Socialist Party two to the upper chamber of the bicameral parliament. Also, the coalition has decided on Durga Paudel, a National People's Front candidate who had lost the House of Representatives general election last year, as the nominee for a member, who the president will nominate.

Fresh faces

This time, there was a lot of excitement around the elections for the 19 seats in the parliament's upper body. The media, rival parties, and even handful members of the ruling parties have put pressure on the ruling coalition partners not to field the candidates who either lost the parliamentary elections held last year or who have or had enjoyed pelf and perks of high positions. They desired that these parties present fresh faces to the National Assembly, which is recognised as the assembly of highly qualified professionals in their specialised sectors. It turned out, nevertheless, that the ruling coalition's parties were unable to adhere to this philosophy and had filed a few candidates who had either lost their previous elections or had held prominent positions.

The Nepali Congress's chief Sher Bahadur Deuba appears to be under intense pressure to name senior leader Krishna Prasad Sitaula as a candidate. With incumbent Upper House chair Ganesh Timalsina's term expiring in one and a half months, Sitaula is expected to replace him. No denying that our political parties' tendency to field or nominate veteran candidates has undoubtedly hurt them; their chairmen and leaders seem unable to withstand the pressure from influential party members. Party leaders also have a special fondness for some members whom they hope to see in parliament, as they would be of assistance to them in difficult circumstances.

As a result, these parties' other leaders and workers undergo suffering and hardship. Many of these party workers and leaders often become so frustrated that they quit their mother party and join others. One such example is Swarnim Wagle, a well-known economist and member of the Nepali Congress, who left the Congress to join the recently established Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) after being denied the opportunity to run for parliament. He joined RSP, and after winning a by-election in the Tanahu district, he was elected to the parliament.

In addition to selecting a few candidates who had already suffered setbacks in the general elections, parties also attempted to entice the main opposition by sharing seats with the party in the Upper House elections. In exchange for the opposition party's cooperation in passing a contentious bill on transitional justice, the leaders of the alliance's two major parties, the Maoist Centre and the Nepali Congress, sought to provide the latter some seats. Additionally, reports suggest that the two parties sought the assistance of the UML chair KP Sharma Oli in handling the irregularities of the telecom industry. Since the UML chairman refrained from publicly endorsing them, the sharing of a few seats with the main opposition could not take place.

> The bicameral parliament's upper body needs to be transformed into an efficient body of experts, which would give our parliament a lot of credibility.

As a result of several of its members' terms ending on March 3, the main opposition will now only hold eight seats in the 59-member Upper House. The seat-sharing talks failed due also to opposition from some ruling party members who were aspirant to the coveted parliamentary membership. In the meantime, the anticipated breakup with the UML, according to observers, is a positive sign for the nation's democracy because democratic principles and spirit guarantee that the opposition should refrain from forming an alliance with the ruling party on contentious and hotly contested matters. If the ruling parties participate in unethical behaviour, the main opposition must do its responsibility to expose them.

Meanwhile, the goal of every election must be to strengthen our system of government. Political parties that have worked hard to build federalism and republicanism in the country must be cautious not to allow the opposing forces to have the upper hand in national politics at this time when the forces hostile to federal republicanism have raised their ugly heads.

Qualified candidates

These days, a number of pro-royalists and pro-royalist parties like the Rastriya Prajatantra Party have expressed extreme disapproval of coalition parties' performances. The reports of involvement of senior leaders in corruption and non-performance in the government have made the matter worse for the coalition. Certain segments of the public have cautioned these political parties that their current performance may dent republicanism, federalism, and secularism, which will greatly appease the forces that want to see a return of monarchy as well as unitary system of governance, besides turning the country into a Hindu state.

Therefore, major ruling parties need to take steps to send qualified candidates to the Upper House. It is disheartening to observe that the Upper House, which ought to consist of specialists selected from several disciplines, has been turned into a chamber of loyal lawmakers hand-picked by party bosses. Because of this, the National Assembly has become an ineffective parliament chamber whose members follow the "order and advice" of their party bosses due to the practice of hand-picking close party friends and confidants. The bicameral parliament's upper body needs to be transformed into an efficient body of experts, which would give our parliament a lot of credibility.

(Upadhyay is former managing editor of this daily)

Need To Tap Tourism Potential



Uttam Maharjan

As per the data made available by the Nepal Tourism Board, a little over one million (1,014876) foreign tourists visited Nepal in 2023. The officials concerned have expressed happiness that the tourism sector is gradually picking up the rhythm it lost owing to the COVID-19 pandemic. They maintain that the country has recovered around 85 per cent of the pre-pandemic figure (2019). The 2023 figure is lower than the pre-pandemic figures of 2018 and 2019. In 2018, the county welcomed 1.17 million tourists, which jumped slightly to 1.19 million in 2019. This is the third time the country has hit the one million mark in the tourism sector. The country was preparing to celebrate the Visit Nepal 2020 campaign when the COVID-19 struck the country along with the rest of the world. With this, the campaign had to be reluctantly revoked.

The COVID-19 pandemic had far-reaching repercussions on the tourism and other sectors. The repercussions have not completely come to an end. Travel restrictions and lockdowns imposed during the COVID-19 years were major blows to the economy. As a result, the country could welcome just 230,085 tourists in 2020, 150,962 in 2021 and 614,869 in 2022. Compared to these figures, the figure for 2023 is encouraging but it is not enough. The country has never been able to welcome even 1.2 million tourists although the country has innumerable attractions to offer to tourists.

Attractions

As per the statistics of 2017, most of the tourists visit the country to observe pilgrimage and heritage sites (70.3 per cent). Pleasure-seeking tourists constitute 34.5 per cent, followed by mountaineering and trekking tourists (13.1 per cent) and others who visit the country for official purposes, conferences or on business (18.0 per cent).

One of the factors contributing to a surge in tourist arrivals in 2023 is the re-opening of the Nepal-China border, increased flight movement from China and record arrivals from India. In March 2023, the Chinese government allowed its citizens to travel to Nepal after a hiatus of three years. Since March 15, the Chinese government has allowed its national travel agencies and online companies to resume, on a pilot basis, outbound group tours for Chinese people to some countries, including Nepal.

In 2023, Indian tourists topped the chart of tourist arrivals, followed by US and Chinese tourists. It may be mentioned that in 2023, Tibetan authorities did not allow around 50 Indian pilgrims who had already booked the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra programme to visit Mansarovar. Frustrated at not being able to visit the pilgrimage site, they instead visited Muktinath and Lumbini, two of the famous pilgrimate sites in the country, on the same package.

The COVID-19 pandemic has subsided now, although the threat has not been completely eliminated. The emergence of a JN.1 sub-variant of the Omicron variant in India and elsewhere has alarmed the health officials to some extent. They have urged the people to be alert and follow the COVID-19 safety protocols. The said sub-variant is highly transmissible.

It need not be reiterated that the country has good prospects for growth in the tourism business. The World Bank and the International Monetary Fund have also predicted that there will be robust growth in tourism activities and the economy of the country will pick up momentum. There is no gainsaying that the country is rich in attractions to be offered to tourists. But what matters is how to manage such touristic attractions and how to explore new destinations. There are 15 national and wildlife parks, two of them being world heritage sites. There is the Asiatic rhinoceros (one-horned rhino) and the Royal Bengal tiger. Eight out of 10 the highest mountains in the world are located in the country. Besides, the country is endowed with topographical attractions, historical or cultural sites, socio-cultural traditions, practices, customs or rituals and many more. The country is a paradise for trekkers, mountaineers and rock climbers. The country is a Mecca for adventure tourists and eco-tourists. Mount Everest and Lumbini are famous all over the world.

> The government should, therefore, realise the potential of tourism and embark upon effective measures to promote the tourism sector by emphasising infrastructure development.

Tourism could be an effective tool for earning foreign currency. It could generate employment opportunities within the country. The current trend of migrating to foreign countries for employment could be mitigated to a great extent with an increase in job opportunities. Tourism could also be a means of alleviating poverty by developing the rural economy. In fact, it leaves much to be desired when it comes to promoting the tourism sector. The officials concerned seem to be complacent with the annual one million target.

Three international airports – Pokhara, Bhairahawa and Gautam Buddha international airports – have come into operation. The Bhairahawa International Airport is a gateway to Lumbini, while the Pokhara International Airport is a pylon to Annapurna, a popular destination for trekkers. These airports could help in increasing the inflow of tourists to the country but these airports have not been able to perform up to the mark. Some people have even raised questions over why these airports were constructed. There could be geopolitical factors behind the sorry state of these airports, especially with India. On the other hand, the proposed construction of the Nijgadh airport has been on the backburner owing to factors like the need for felling a large number of trees.

Infrastructure

There is no denying the fact that infrastructure is the key to promoting the tourism sector. When it comes to infrastructure development, the progress achieved so far is far from satisfactory. It seems infrastructure development is not the priority of any governments, whether federal, state or local. Travel vlogs uploaded to YouTube show that travellers have to travel along dust roads to reach a site of touristic attraction such as a pilgrimage site or a historical site. When the local units were being looked after by the government employees before the 2074 BS local elections, it was alleged that lack of people's representatives had hindered local development. Now, the local elections have since been held twice but local development, especially in terms of infrastructure development, is yet to take off satisfactorily.

The government should, therefore, realise the potential of tourism and embark upon effective measures to promote the tourism sector by emphasising infrastructure development. In 2023, Thailand welcomed over 27 million tourists. The country cannot achieve such a figure at one go but there is no reason why the country cannot attract more and more tourists in the years ahead.

(Maharjan has been regularly writing on contemporary issues for this daily since 2000.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 8, 1974

17 Officials To Be Trained In US

Kathmandu, Jan. 8: Under the manpower development programme, 17 Nepalese officials will be trained in the United States by June 1974, it is learnt.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Tourism Bonanza

This is in reference to your news story, *"Nepal achieves tourism target, but yet to reach pre-COVID level"* published in Jan. 4. The country deserves a thumping pat on the back for the mission impossible in tourism - pocketing the target of 1 million tourists. Congratulations to everyone involved in rewriting post-COVID tourism history, and if we continue with the current pace, tourism will bring us untold prosperity.

At just 48 dollars a day tourist receipt, we should be able to build a solid foundation to go from strength to strength.

What is the total receipt from tourism for the calendar year 2023? For example, the Phillippines posted 8.7 billion dollars in tourism receipts in 2023. Uzbekistan targets 10 million tourists and 2.5 billion dollars in 2024, while Strasbourg citizens were shivering in fear of being overrun by an estimated three million tourists during the recent Christmas and New Year.



The French city bordering Germany has a population of only 300,000. As the country of Sita's maternal home, Lord Rama's in-laws, the temple in Ayodhya could bring us a windfall of Rama's followers.

Like Strasbourg, we could see ourselves overrun by millions of Hindu pilgrims, a tourism bonanza.

Manohar Shrestha
Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

A man was driving down the road. He passed a traffic camera and saw it flash.

Astounded that he had been caught speeding when he was under the speed limit, he turned around and, going even slower, he passed by the camera.

Again, he saw it flash. He couldn't believe it! So he turned and, going at snail's pace, he passed the camera.

AGAIN, he saw the camera flash. He guessed it must have a fault, and home he went.

Four weeks later he received three traffic fines in the mail, all for not wearing a seatbelt.

Russia evacuates hundreds from border city amid Ukrainian strikes

AFP
Ukraine, Jan. 8



Russia said Monday it had moved some 300 people from the border city of Belgorod due to Ukrainian shelling, the biggest evacuation from a major Russian city since the conflict began.

The unprecedented announcement follows waves of deadly strikes by Kyiv's forces on Belgorod, which lies less than 20 miles (32 kilometres) from the Ukrainian border.

Some 300 residents who decided to leave are now being housed in temporary accommodation in the towns of Stary Oskol, Gubkin and the Korochansky district, further from the border, regional governor Vyacheslav Gladkov said.

"Over the past 24 hours we received 1,300 requests to send Belgorod children to school camps away from the city in other regions," he added.

The Kremlin has tried to maintain a semblance of normalcy on the home front, but recent strikes on Belgorod have brought the Ukraine conflict closer to home for Russians.

On December 30, Ukrainian shelling of the city killed 25 people, prompting schools to shut for an extended period.

Moscow vowed to intensify strikes on Ukraine in response to the attack, the deadliest in Russia since the start of the war in February 2022.

At least four people were killed and dozens injured in a fresh wave of Russian strikes across Ukraine on Monday, regional officials said.

Kyiv warned last week it only had enough ammunition to withstand a few more powerful attacks, and has asked for more Western help.

"The enemy launched dozens of missiles at peaceful cities and villages of Ukraine," Ukraine's deputy head of the presidency Oleksiy Kuleba said.

A total of 59 projectiles were fired at Ukraine, including drones and missiles, the air force said, adding that Moscow had targeted civilian infrastructure.

Russian missiles hit a shopping centre and high-rise buildings in President Volodymyr Zelensky's hometown of Kryvyi Rih, killing one person, Kuleba said.

"In Kryvyi Rih, there are many breakages in power grids, there are power outages, and electric transport does not work," he said.

Two people were killed in a missile attack in the western region of Khmelnytsky, far from the frontlines in the east, Ukrainian police said.

In the eastern region of Kharkiv, an elderly woman pulled from the rubble of her house in the city of Zmiiv also died, regional governor Oleg Synegubov said.

Russia said it had only struck "military" targets in its latest defence ministry briefing.

The attacks come a day after Japanese Foreign Minister Yoko Kamikawa paid a surprise visit to Kyiv Sunday, where she said Tokyo was "determined" to keep supporting Ukraine.

Kamikawa, the first high-level foreign official to visit Kyiv this year, announced new deliveries of defence equipment and discussed Tokyo's plans to host a February conference to promote Ukraine's economic reconstruction.

Hasina celebrates 'absolute victory'

AFP
Dhaka, Jan. 8



PHOTO: AFP
A policeman walks past a portrait of Bangladesh's Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina on Monday, a day after she won re-election for a fifth term.

Bangladesh's Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina on Monday dismissed the opposition's criticism of the country's general election as "illegitimate" as she celebrated securing her fifth term in power.

Hasina has presided over breakneck economic growth in a country once beset by grinding poverty, but her government has been accused of rampant human rights abuses and a ruthless crackdown on dissent.

"The election was free and fair," she told reporters in her first comments since the vote on Sunday, where her party took three-quarters of seats in parliament after polls boycotted by the opposition, with turnout at a meagre 41.8 percent.

"If any party does not participate in the election, it does not mean there is no democracy," she said, adding that "those who want to criticise can criticise".

The opposition Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP), which has seen its ranks diminished by mass arrests, called a general strike and, along with dozens of others, refused to participate.

Senior BNP leader Moyeen Khan called it a "fake election" and said the government was "illegitimate", he told reporters in Dhaka on Monday.

Election Commission secretary Moniruzzaman Talukder said Hasina's party had won 223 seats in Sunday's polls, but the support of other lawmakers means her actual control over the 300-seat parliament is even higher, analysts said.

"It was a farce election, like a local neighbourhood or a market association election," said Mohammad Shahin, 42, who pulls a rickshaw.

Hasina, 76, called for citizens to show faith in the democratic process and branded the BNP "a terrorist organisation" after she voted on Sunday.

"This is a one-party parliament," Ali Riaz of Illinois State University told AFP, adding that "only the allies of the Awami League had the opportunity to participate".

Bangladesh was the first in key South Asian elections this year where embattled opposition parties face a tough battle, including in Pakistan, where jailed former prime minister Imran Khan has been rejected as a candidate, and in neighbouring India.

The Jatiya Party, which won 11 seats, is a long-time ally of Hasina's Awami League, as are many of the 61 independent candidates, said Mubashar Hasan, a political scientist at the University of Oslo.

"This election has legitimised one-party rule in the country with no credible and effective opposition in the parliament," Hasan told AFP.

"Almost all the independent candidates who won the parliamentary seats are also part of the Awami League."

Among the victors was Bangladesh cricket team captain Shakib Al Hasan, who won a seat for the ruling party.

EU Council president to step down early



PHOTO: AFP
Hungary's Prime Minister Viktor Orban, left, speaks with European Council President Charles Michel at an EU summit in Brussels on March 23, 2023.

AFP
France, Jan. 8

European Council president Charles Michel announced Sunday that he will step down early, setting off a race against time for EU leaders to find a successor for the key position.

The 48-year-old former Belgian prime minister has been organising EU summits and government meetings since 2019 and should leave office in November.

But he said he would leave early as he will stand in the European parliament elections to be held in June. Michel will be the head of the liberal Reformist Movement in the elections. "Four years after starting my term as a European leader, it's my responsibility to give an account of my work these past years and to propose a project for Europe's future," Michel said.

He added that he was ready to take a "personal risk" in standing down in such controversial circumstances.

An EU summit is scheduled for just after the June 6-9 elections, and "at this moment it will have to decide when my successor will take up the job," Michel said.

If European Union leaders cannot find a successor by then, Hungary's nationalist prime minister, Viktor Orban, who has had frequent battles with Brussels, could take the job temporarily.

Blinken to meet Saudi crown prince before heading to Israel

AFP
Abu Dhabi, Jan. 8



PHOTO: AFP
US Secretary of State Antony Blinken gestures as he arrives in Abu Dhabi on January 7, 2024, during his week-long trip aimed at calming tensions across the Middle East.

US Secretary of State Antony Blinken will meet Saudi Arabia's de facto ruler on Monday before heading to Israel as part of efforts to stop the Gaza war spiralling into a regional conflict.

Blinken will discuss Red Sea attacks by the Iran-backed Huthi rebels in Yemen, Saudi Arabia's southern neighbour, during his talks with Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman.

Their meeting will also touch on a potential normalisation of ties between Saudi Arabia and Israel after initial discussions were put on hold by the Gaza crisis, a senior official said.

Blinken "emphasised the importance of preventing further spread of the conflict", during talks in Abu Dhabi on Monday with United Arab Emirates President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan in Abu Dhabi, a US summary of the meeting said.

"This is a conflict that could easily metastasise, causing even more insecurity and even more suffering," Blinken said on Sunday in Qatar, the previous leg of his tour.

The war in Gaza started with Hamas's unprecedented October 7 attack on Israel, which resulted in about 1,140 deaths, most of them civilians, according to an AFP tally based on official Israeli figures.

Israel has responded with relentless bombardment and a ground invasion that have killed at least 22,835 people, most of them women and children, according to the health ministry in Hamas-run Gaza.

After his talks with UAE President Sheikh Mohamed, Blinken is flying to Al Ula, a historic oasis city in western Saudi Arabia.

Yemen's Huthi rebels, vowing solidarity with the Palestinian cause, have launched more than 100 drone and missile attacks on targets in Israel and the Red Sea, disrupting traffic in the key shipping route.

The United States and 11 allies last week warned of unspecified consequences if the attacks continue.

But the situation is tense for Riyadh as it coincides with attempts to settle a long-running war between the Huthis and a Saudi-led international coalition.

Blinken's meeting with the crown prince is also an opportunity to sound out the Saudis on the prospect of an eventual normalisation with Israel, a senior US official said -- even if progress appears unlikely while the war continues.

PRISM

Venomous snake removed from public toilet

Australia: A wildlife wrangler in Australia relocated a venomous snake found lurking in an unusual place the bowl of a public toilet. Tennille Bankes, of the Wildlife Empire animal sanctuary and relocation service, said in a TikTok post she was called out to a public restroom in Goondiwindi, Queensland, on a report of an unflushable blockage in a toilet. Bankes arrived to find the toilet bowl occupied by a blue-bellied black snake, a venomous species also known as a spotted black snake.

The video shoes Bankes using a hook to scoop the serpent out of the toilet and into a bag, which she then secures closed.

Bankes said the snake was released into a "nearby bush land."

Owl takes a ride in the back of Oregon deputy's patrol car

Oregon: An owl that became involved in an altercation with a pickup truck ended up taking a ride in the back of an Oregon recruit deputy's patrol car.

The Clackamas County Sheriff's Office said in a Facebook post that a recruit deputy ended up coming to the assistance of a tow truck driver "whose vehicle had an unexpected encounter with an owl."

The sheriff's office shared a photo of the owl taking a ride to a local animal hospital in the back seat of the recruit's patrol vehicle."We wish the feathered patient a swift and smooth recovery," the post said.

(Agencies)

Approval given to use AI in writing legal opinions

AP
London, Jan. 8



PHOTO: AP
Judges walk into Parliament after a Service at Westminster Abbey for the opening of the new legal year in London, Friday, Oct. 1, 2021.

England's 1,000-year-old legal system — still steeped in traditions that include wearing wigs and robes — has taken a cautious step into the future by giving judges permission to use artificial intelligence to help produce rulings.

The Courts and Tribunals Judiciary last month said AI could help write opinions but stressed it shouldn't be used for research or legal analyses because the technology can fabricate information and provide misleading, inaccurate and biased information.

At a time when scholars and legal experts are pondering a future when AI could replace lawyers, help select jurors or even decide cases, the approach spelled out Dec. 11 by the judiciary is restrained. But for a profession slow to embrace technological change, it's a proactive step as government and industry — and society in general — react to a rapidly advancing technology alternately portrayed as a panacea and a menace.

Abbott and other legal experts applauded the judiciary for addressing the latest iterations of AI and said the guidance would be widely viewed by courts and jurists around the world who are eager to use AI or anxious about what it might bring.

In taking what was described as an initial step, England and Wales moved toward the forefront of courts addressing AI, though it's not the first such guidance.

Five years ago, the European Commission for the Efficiency of Justice of the Council of Europe issued an ethical charter on the use of AI in court systems. While that document is not up to date with the latest technology, it did address core principles such as accountability and risk mitigation that judges should abide by, said Giulia Gentile, a lecturer at Essex Law School who studies the use of AI in legal and justice systems.

Although U.S. Supreme Court Chief Justice John Roberts addressed the pros and cons of artificial intelligence in his annual report, the federal court system in America has not yet established guidance on AI, and state and county courts are too fragmented for a universal approach. But individual courts and judges at the federal and local levels have set their own rules, said Cary Coglianese, a law professor at the University of Pennsylvania.

The guidance shows the courts' acceptance of the technology, but not a full embrace, Gentile said. She was critical of a section that said judges don't have to disclose their use of the technology and questioned why there was no accountability mechanism.

In its effort to maintain the court's integrity while moving forward, the guidance is rife with warnings about the limitations of the technology and possible problems if a user is unaware of how it works.

At the top of the list is an admonition about chatbots, such as ChatGPT, the conversational tool that exploded into public view last year and has generated the most buzz over the technology because of its ability to swiftly compose everything from term papers to songs to marketing materials.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1816 – Humphry Davy tests his safety lamp for miners at Hebburn Colliery.
1822 – The Portuguese prince Pedro I of Brazil decides to stay in Brazil against the orders of the Portuguese King João VI, beginning the Brazilian independence process.
1858 – British forces finally defeat Rajab Ali Khan of Chittagong
1878 – Umberto I becomes King of Italy.
1991 – Representatives from the United States and Iraq meet at the Geneva Peace Conference to try to find a peaceful resolution to the Iraqi invasion of Kuwait.
2004 – An inflatable boat carrying illegal Albanian emigrants stalls near the Karaburun Peninsula en route to Brindisi, Italy; exposure to the elements kills 28. This is the second deadliest marine disaster in Albanian history.
2015 – A mass poisoning at a funeral in Mozambique involving beer that was contaminated with Burkholderia gladioli leaves 75 dead and over 230 people ill.

CIAA APPEALS CASES AT SC

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 8

The Commission for the Investigation of the Abuse of Authority (CIAA) appealed cases in the Supreme Court on Monday expressing dissatisfaction over the verdicts of the Special Court, Kathmandu on various dates.

The CIAA filed Case No. 076-CR-0431 of the Special Court against Jitendra Shakya and his wife Mithila Shakya in the Supreme Court.

According to the CIAA, Jitendra had illegally acquired Rs. 22.5 million. During the inspection of Jitendra's income and expenditure from the time he entered civil service on July 17, 1977 until the end of Fiscal Year 2019/020, it was revealed that his total income was Rs. 15.6 million while expenditure was Rs. 38.1 million.

The CIAA demanded Jitendra be fined Rs. 22.5 million and punished in accordance with the Prevention of Corruption Act 1960 and Clause 20 (2) of the Prevention of Corruption Act 2002. Similarly, it demanded the confiscation of undisclosed assets in his and his wife's name worth Rs. 22.5 million.

VISITING IRISH UPPER HOUSE CHAIR CALLS ON NA CHAIR

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 8

Visiting Chairperson of the Seanad Éireann, the Upper House of Ireland Jerry Buttimer called on National Assembly Chair, Ganesh Prasad Timilsina, at the latter's office in Singha Durbar today.

Buttimer is on a five-day official visit to Nepal. During the meeting, Chairperson Timilsina requested for Ireland's support in lifting the EU ban on Nepali airlines and increasing scholarship for Nepali students in Ireland.

On the occasion, Chairperson Buttimer assured of initiating dialogue and discussion on lifting the ban on Nepali airlines in Europe, according to Chair Timilsina's secretariat.



PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN

Minister for Urban Development Sita Gurung along with parliamentarians observing the under-construction building of Federal Parliament at Singha Durbar in Kathmandu on Monday.

Note of dissent written on candidate selection in NC

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 8

The Nepali Congress, after holding marathon meetings lasting for more than two days, finalised the names of its candidates for the National Assembly member election only on Monday morning. Yet, some leaders including party general secretary Gagan Kumar Thapa wrote notes of dissent on the decision.

A meeting of the party Central Work Execution Committee held at the party central office, Sanepa of Lalitpur endorsed the decisions of the NC Parliamentary Board meeting held on Sunday.

NC chief secretary Krishna Prasad Paudel in a statement informed that Krishna Prasad Sitaula, Ananda Prasad Dhungana, Jeet Jung Basnet, Bishnudevi Pudasaini, Kirana Babu Shrestha, Padam Bahadur Pariyar, Bishnu Kumari Sapkota, Krishna Bahadur Rokaya, Baldev Bohara and Narayan Dutta Bhatta were nominated as candidates for the National Assembly member election from the NC.

However, NC general secretary Thapa, leaders Arjun Narasingh KC and Bal Bahadur KC wrote notes of dissent objecting to the decision.

Thapa in his note of dissent wrote that the Parliamentary Board did not pay attention to the constitutional provisions and candidate selection standards set by the party central committee meeting.

He wrote the decision did not ensure equal justice and opportunity to friends of all levels without any bias in the party, and this kind of biased decision would weaken the party's internal democracy.

Thapa said although he had a different voice over the decision, he would fully participate in the implementation of the decision taken by a majority in the party.

Likewise, two other leaders, Arjun Narasingh and Bala Bahadur KC, submitted their 5-point dissent to party president Sher Bahadur Deuba in writing.

They said the decision of candidate nomination violated the standards fixed by the Central Working Committee meeting, and it had created distrust over the party decision. They also said that picking candidates without giving full shape to the Parliamentary Board was a serious mistake and an authoritarian practice. The Madhesi community and inclusiveness as well as one side of the party leadership were neglected while picking the candidates.

'People's intervention necessary in law making'

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 8

Prime Minister and Chairperson of CPN (Maoist Center) Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that people's regulation, monitoring and intervention are necessary in policy making.

In a review meeting of the completion of the CPN (MC)'s special transformation campaign with the people here today, the Prime Minister said that he wishes to integrate people's monitoring and intervention in the governance system.

He said that preparations are being made to present the next policy and programmes, and the budget estimates of the government through the direct participation of people's representatives and the people.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that the budget will be based on comprehensive deliberations on the policy and program of the government. "This will be the most democratic framework and process that we will be adopting in relation to the government's policy and program," he said.

The Prime Minister said that the government has accomplished some new tasks in the first year and will move forward with a more effective action plan in the coming year.

"Action against corruption is unprecedented in history and necessary efforts are also being made in improving service delivery and ensuring good governance. Based on this, the next year will be better for which the government requires full support of the party."

CPN (MC) Chair Prachanda said that the party's standing committee will meet soon to be followed by legislation conference. "The draft of the party statute has been prepared, which will be sent to the grassroots committees to hold the legislation conference in the form of a campaign," Prachanda said, "In the meantime, the process of party unity will also be advanced, while the Samajbadi Front will be strengthened.

Eight imprisoned in 138 kg gold smuggling case

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 8

Eight alleged gold smugglers involved in the 138-kg gold smuggling case have been sent to jail.

A single bench of Judge Shankar Bahadur Rai of the District Court, Kathmandu, ordered to send the eight offenders to prison on Sunday.

After the arrest of Chandra Ghale of Gorkha, who had brought 14 kg of gold from Dubai to Kathmandu via Tribhuvan International Airport on the night of December 7, persons involved in the case were revealed.

The investigation committee of TIA's Customs Office concluded that Min Bahadur Ghale and his group had smuggled 138 kg of gold.

Chandra Ghale, who brought gold last time on December 7, Min Bahadur Ghale, who managed gold smuggling in Nepal, and Krishan Kumar Shrestha of Syangja, who smuggled gold earlier, have been sent to jail as per the verdict, according to information officer Chandra Prasad Panthi of the District Court.

The case under gold smuggling and revenue leakage was filed on January 1 making 10 smugglers as defendants claiming Rs. 1.4 billion to be recovered from them.

DB alias Dan Bahadur Gurung and his wife Bina Gurung who were made defendants in the case are absconding.

Similarly, the employees of the Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal (CAAN) who delivered the smuggled gold from the airport to Min Bahadur Ghale's house have also been jailed.

Airport employees Radhakrishna Shrestha, Lek Bahadur Tamang, Ramesh Deula, Anil Shrestha, and Sher Bahadur Basnet too were sent to jail.

However, the cases of others linked to the smuggling are pending because of a lack of their details.

The government had formed a committee headed by Chief Customs Officer of the TIA Mani Ram Paudel to investigate the gold smuggling case on December 8. The committee, led by Customs Officer Mani Ram Poudel, includes Deputy Superintendent of Police Surya Prasad Subedi, Customs Officer Prakash Niraula, Dilli Prasad Sharma, and Officer Manju Thapa.

Two Palestinian journalists killed in Israeli strikes

AP
Rafah, Gaza Strip, Jan. 8

An apparent Israeli airstrike killed two Palestinian journalists in southern Gaza on Sunday, including an Al Jazeera journalist who lost four close relatives earlier in the war.

Hamza Dahdouh is the son of veteran Al Jazeera correspondent Wael Dahdouh, whose wife, two other children and a grandson were killed by a previous Israeli strike.

Dahdouh has continued to report on the fighting between Israel and Hamas even as it has taken a devastating toll on his own family, becoming a symbol for many of the perils faced by Palestinian journalists, dozens of whom have been killed while covering the conflict.

Hamza Dahdouh, who was also working for Al Jazeera, and Mustafa Tharaya, a freelance journalist, were killed when a strike hit their car while they were driving to an assignment in southern Gaza, according to Al Jazeera. A third journalist, Hazem Rajab, was seriously wounded, it said.

Amer Abu Amr, a photojournalist, said in a Facebook post that he and another journalist, Ahmed al-Bursh, survived the strike. There was no immediate comment from the Israeli military.

Wael Dahdouh, 53, has been the face of Al Jazeera's 24-hour coverage of this war and previous rounds of fighting for millions of Arabic-speaking viewers across the region, nearly always appearing on air in the blue helmet and flak jacket worn to identify journalists in the Palestinian territories.

Speaking to Al Jazeera after his son's burial, Dahdouh vowed to continue reporting on the war.

"The whole world must look at what is happening here in the Gaza Strip," he said. "What is happening is a great injustice to defenseless people, civilian people. It is also unfair for us as journalists."

In a statement, Al Jazeera accused Israel of deliberately targeting the reporters and condemned the "ongoing crimes committed by the Israeli occupation forces against journalists and media professionals in Gaza." It also vowed to take "all legal measures to prosecute the perpetrators of these crimes."

Dahdouh was reporting on the offensive in late October when he received word that his wife, daughter and another son had been killed in an Israeli airstrike.

North Korea's Kim turns 40

But there are no public celebrations of his birthday

AP
Seoul, South Korea, Jan. 8

North Korean leader Kim Jong Un turned 40 on Monday with no announced public celebrations at home, after he entered the new year with artillery barrages into the sea and vows to expand his nuclear arsenal.

Since taking power in late 2011, Kim, the third generation of his family to rule North Korea, is believed to have established an absolute leadership similar to his predecessors. But his birthday has yet to be officially celebrated, unlike his late father Kim Jong Il and grandfather Kim Il Sung. Their birthdays are two of the North's biggest holidays and are marked with great fanfare, loyalty campaigns and sometimes massive military parades.

On Monday, North Korea's state news agency published a lengthy article extolling Kim's guidance of major construction projects in the past decade. It also reported Kim visited a chicken farm with his daughter the previous day. But it made no mention of his birthday.

Some observers speculate Kim may think he's still relatively too young or needs bigger achievements to hold such lavish birthday festivities. Others say the lack of a public birthday bash may be related to his concerns about attention to his late Japan-born mother.

Kim's headlong pursuit of a bigger nuclear arsenal has invited punishing U.S.-led sanctions, which together with border closures during the pandemic were believed to have badly hurt the North's fragile economy. Kim has subsequently admitted policy failures as his vow that North Korea would "never have to tighten their belts again" remained unfulfilled.

"For Kim, it's still probably politically burdensome to idolize himself as he's still young and hasn't accumulated much achievements," said Hong Min, an analyst at Seoul's Korea Institute for National Unification.

Kim Yeol Soo, an expert at South Korea's Korea Institute for Military Affairs, said it will likely take some time for his birthday to become an official holiday because elderly members of the North's ruling elite would still think he's too young. Birthdays are central to the mythology of Kim Il Sung and Kim Jong Il, who had ruled North Korea with a god-like status since the country's founding in 1948.

Their birthdays — April 15 for Kim Il Sung, and Feb. 16 for Kim Jong Il — are typically celebrated with tributes to their giant statues, dance parties, fireworks and art performances.

RSS should serve as bridge....

be considered as the government programme," she said, adding that it was equally important to establish the responsibility of the province and local governments as well in such endeavours.

The inclusive characteristic that Nepal has adopted following the latest political change is itself exemplary in the world, she said, adding that the outcomes of inclusion have started becoming visible in state apparatuses.She also said that Nepal has been transformed into a multi-lingual, multi-religious and multi-cultural nation in a true sense after the latest political transformations.

"All the Nepali people, with multi-ethnic, multilingual, multi-religious, multicultural characteristics and in geographical diversities, and having common aspirations and being united by a bond of allegiance to national independence, territorial integrity, national interest and prosperity of Nepal, collectively constitute the nation," she said. "All languages spoken as the mother tongues in Nepal are the languages of the nation." "A province may, by province law, determine one or more than one languages of the nation spoken by a majority of people within the State as its official language(s), in addition to the Nepali language," she reminded the Constitutional provision.

There is also the Language Commission established constitutionally to make recommendations to the Government of Nepal, on the measures to be adopted for the protection, promotion and development of languages, the Minister said, adding that no one should feel exploitation and discrimination based on languages.

During the event, Krishna Bahadur Raut, the Secretary at the Ministry of Communications and Information Technology, lauded the inclusion of mother tongues in the RSS news bulletin, recognising it as a significant step towards promoting mother languages, literature, and safeguarding mother tongues.

"Many languages currently face the threat of extinction. No language can sustain in the absence of their archiving and use in communications. It is a milestone achievement for the RSS to disseminate the contents in the mother tongue."

He also advised the RSS to incorporate other more mother languages in its services, pledging all sorts of possible support on behalf of the Ministry towards that end.

Chair of Federation of Nepali Journalists, Bipul Pokhrel said the role of news contents on mother tongues was vital to increase civic acceptance and ownership to media. The FNJ Chair proposed the RSS to provide its contents free of cost to small-scale media.

Advertisement Board Chair Laxman Humagain praised the RSS for its move to disseminate the contents in the mother tongue.

RSS Executive Chair Dharmendra Jha said the diversification of the RSS service suggested the RSS partnership with the government for its policy departure. "The moment it itself is historic. The RSS has not only accepted democracy, federalism and inclusion, but has internalised them and implemented them."

RSS General Manager Siddha Raj Rai expressed his hope that the incorporation of mother tongue contents in the RSS news service would contribute to making news dissemination more effective and promoting the mother tongues that are spoken in the country.

Sharing about the RSS plans for diversification of its services, he said they plan to launch the additional news service in a way that will represent at least one language from one province.

Coronavirus...

variant will be provided by the ministry soon," he added.

Similarly, RSS adds, Ganesh Saud, Chief of the Health Desk set up at Gauriphanta checkpoint, told that coronavirus infection was found in 10 people who returned from India so far.

"We have been conducting antigen tests among the India returnees and 10 cases of coronavirus have been recorded so far," he mentioned.

Saud said that samples were collected and sent to Kathmandu to confirm the variant of corona two weeks ago, but its report has not been received yet, added the Health Desk Chief.

However, coronavirus has not been confirmed on Nepalis returning home using the Gaddachauki checkpoint of Kanchanpur so far, according to the District Health Office, Kanchanpur.

9,169 temporary...

Shivalaya and Junichande rural municipalities.

As the local level governments did not transfer the funds sent by the government to the earthquake victims so that they could build warm houses to live in winter, some of the victims who had been residing under tents perished because of cold-induced ailments.

According to Hari Chandra Sharma, information officer and administrative officer of the district administration office, the office has sent the first instalment of funds to the account of the local disaster management committee for the construction of temporary shelters to protect the people from the cold. Sharma said that the local governments have been instructed to expedite the fund distribution task.

PAKISTAN'S COURT SCRAPS A LIFETIME BAN ON POLITICIANS

AP
Islamabad, Jan. 8

Pakistan's Supreme Court on Monday scrapped a lifetime ban on politicians with convictions from contesting elections, paving the way for former Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif to run for the fourth time. The court ruling will also enable other politicians to run for parliament in the Feb. 8 elections.

The lifetime ban on convicted politicians was imposed in 2018. Under a new court order passed on Monday, convicted politicians would be barred from running only for five years.

Sharif's party said he will seek a fourth term after returning in October from a four-year self-exile in London to avoid serving prison sentences on corruption charges. They were overturned on appeal after his return.

India court restores life prison sentences for 11 Hindu men

AP
New Delhi, Jan. 8

India's top court on Monday restored life prison sentences for 11 Hindu men who raped a Muslim woman during deadly religious rioting two decades ago and asked the convicts to surrender to the authorities within two weeks.

The Hindu men were convicted in 2008 of rape and murder. They were released in 2022 after serving 14 years in prison.

The victim, who is now in her 40s, was pregnant when she was brutally gang-raped in 2002 in western Gujarat state during communal rioting that was some of India's worst religious violence with over 1,000 people, mostly Muslims, killed.

Seven members of the woman's family, including her 3-year-old daughter, were killed during the riots. The Associated Press generally doesn't identify victims of sexual assault.

The men were eligible for remission of their sentence under a policy that was in place at the time of their convictions. At the time of their release, officials in Gujarat, where Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Bharatiya Janata Party holds power, had said the convicts were granted remission because they had completed over 14 years in jail.

A revised policy adopted in 2014 by the federal government prohibits remission release for those convicted of certain crimes, including rape and murder.

Fifteen artists awarded

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 8



PHOTO: TRN

A total of 15 artists were honoured on the occasion of the commemoration day of National Heritage Araniko and the 29th foundation day of the Commercial Artist Association of Nepal (CAAN) in Kathmandu on Monday.

Senior artist Hari Prasad Sharma was honoured with the 'Surendra Pradhan Lifetime Achievement Award', accompanied by a cash prize of Rs. 25,000. Likewise, Santa Kumar Shakya and Prakash Thapa were awarded the 'Krodhakala Shiromani Award' with cash prizes of Rs. 20,000 and Rs. 15,000, respectively.

Similarly, Sujan Bir Bajracharya received the 'Mulmi Graphic Design Award', Laxmi Neupane the 'Hem-Ganga Women's Art Talent Award' and Shyam Bahadur Shrestha the 'CAAN Ideal Art Award'. Each of them bagged a cash prize of Rs. 10,000.

On the occasion, Ganesh Lama received the 'Nirwana Art Award', Shrawan Chaudhary the 'CAAN Sigdel Art Award', and 'Thakur Prasad-Indira Mainali Sculpture Award' was presented to Laxman Bhujel, along with certificates and Rs. 10,000 each.

Mahendra Rai was honoured with the 'Balkrishna Memorial Art Award', Gyanendra Biwas with the 'Narayan Devi Memorial Award', Sanuraj Dangol with the 'Rajesh Manandhar Cartoon Award', and Susmita Moktan was presented with the 'Richa Mainali Rimal Memorial Award', each receiving a cash prize of Rs. 5,000.

Presenting the awards, Sunita Dangol, the Deputy Mayor of the Kathmandu Metropolitan City, said that the Metropolitan City is always ready to discuss and consider suggestions from artists to enhance the city's beauty through art.

Concerning the tax levied on technology and other hoarding boards currently placed in the city, she said that artists and related sectors should submit proper and written suggestions to the metropolitan city.

These suggestions could then be included in the upcoming policies and programmes of the metropolis, she added. Lalkaji Lama, Vice-Chancellor of the Nepal Academy of Fine Arts, pointed out the need for formulating a policy to invest a portion of the revenue collected from museums and tourism fees in heritage areas for the promotion of art and artists.

He emphasised that the government should develop a plan with investment to encourage artists dedicated to creating such art, while domestic and foreign tourists pay a fee to see artistic heritage in the area.

President of the association, IV Malla, said that the association is active in developing artists and the art sector, promoting a professional environment in art.

Rai, other finalists seek votes in singing reality

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Ilam, Jan. 8



A campaign has been launched in the home district of Ilam to support singer Binod Rai, who is in the final round of the singing reality show The Voice of Nepal Season 5.

The grand finale of the popular singing reality show is scheduled for this Friday. Competing for the coveted title alongside Rai are Makar Yonjan, Nogen Limbu and Kumar Prayas.

At the meantime, various musical programmes and campaign are being organised in different locations across Ilam to support and celebrate singer Binod. During an event organised by Pancham Sangeet Pratishthan at Sombare in Ilam's Phikkal, singer Rai performed several songs and requested votes from the district residents.

He urged all district residents to vote and help him secure victory.

Singer Rai said, "I need your votes for the final round. Please, vote for me, and with your support, I will do the job of keeping the head of Ilam district high,"

Bhupendra Rai, a singer from Ilam, said that a district-wide campaign was conducted to ensure Binod's victory.

Programmes have been organised in Phikkal and Ilam, and Rai stated, "The time has come to elevate the name of Ilam in the field of music. We appeal to everyone to contribute and help."

The 'Win Binod' campaign has been carried out across all 10 local municipalities of Ilam. Additionally, music lovers in Jhapa and Morang have joined the campaign to support Binod.

The campaign has also been launched in Morang's Pathari Shanishchare, where 33-year-old Rai, who has a permanent home in Phakphokthum Rural Municipality of Ilam, studied.

Like Binod, other finalists are also campaigning for votes through social media and their respective home districts.



PHOTO: AP

Barbie actress Margot Robbie posing for a photograph at the 81st Golden Globe Awards at the Beverly Hilton in Beverly Hills on Sunday.

12TH FAIL BECOMES HIGHEST RATED INDIAN FILM ON IMDB

AGENCIES
Mumbai, Jan. 8

Filmmaker Vidhu Vinod Chopra's 12th Fail has passed with meritorious results. The Vikrant Massey-led biographical drama continues to win hearts as it has now become the highest rated Indian film of all time on IMDb.

On the list of top 250 Indian film on IMDb, 12th Fail has secured the number one spot with a rating of 9.2 out of ten. The other four films in the top five Indian movies of all time include the 1993 animated film Ramayana: The Legend of Prince Rama, Mani Ratnam's Nayakan, Hrishikesh Mukherjee's Gol Maal and actor R Madhavan'd directorial debut Rocketry: The Nambi Effect.

With its rating of 9.2, 12th Fail is ahead of some of the biggest, most acclaimed Hollywood blockbusters of 2023, including Spider-Man: Across the Spider-Verse (rated 8.6), Christopher Nolan's Oppenheimer (8.4), Guardians of the Galaxy Vol. 3 (7.9), Martin Scorsese's Killers of the Flower Moon (7.8), John Wick: Chapter 4 (7.7) and Gret Gerwig's Barbie (6.9) headlined by Margot Robbie.

Based on a book by Anurag Pathak and starring Vikrant Massey and Medha Shankar, 12th Fail chronicled the life of Manoj Kumar Sharma, who overcame extreme poverty to become an Indian Police Service officer.

'Oppenheimer' dominates Golden Globes

AP
Los Angeles, Jan. 8



Christopher Nolan's blockbuster biopic "Oppenheimer" dominated the 81st Golden Globes, winning five awards including best drama, while Yorgos Lanthimos' Frankenstein riff "Poor Things" pulled off an upset victor over "Barbie" to triumph in the best comedy or musical category.

If awards season has been building toward a second match-up of Barbenheimer, this round went to "Oppenheimer." The film also won best director for Nolan, best drama actor for Cillian Murphy, best supporting actor for Robert Downey Jr. and for Ludwig Göransson's score.

"I don't think it was a no-brainer by any stretch of the imagination to make a three-hour talky movie — R-rated by the way — about one of the darkest developments in our history," said producer Emma Thomas accepting the night's final award and thanking Universal chief Donna Langley.

Along with best comedy or musical, "Poor Things" also won for Emma Stone's performance as Bella, a Victorian-era woman experiencing a surreal sexual awakening. "I see this as a romcom," said Stone. "But in the sense that Bella falls in love with life itself, rather than a person. She accepts the good and the bad in equal measure, and that really made me look at life differently."

Lily Gladstone won best actress in a dramatic film for Martin Scorsese's "Killers of the Flower Moon." Gladstone, who began her speech speaking the language of her native tribe, Blackfeet Nation, is the first Indigenous winner in the category.

"This is a historic win," said Gladstone. "It doesn't just belong to me."

The Globes were in their ninth decade but facing a new and uncertain chapter. After a tumultuous few years of scandal, the Hollywood Foreign Press Association was dissolved, leaving a new Globes, on a new network (CBS), to try to regain its perch as the third biggest award show of the year, after the Oscars and Grammys. Even the menu (sushi from Nobu) was remade.

"Golden Globes journalists, thank you for changing your game, therefore changing your name," said Downey in his acceptance speech.

It got off to a rocky start. Host Jo Koy took the stage at the Beverly Hilton International Ballroom in Beverly Hills, California . The Filipino American stand-up hit on some expected topics: Ozempic, Meryl Streep's knack for winning awards and the long-running "Oppenheimer." ("I needed another hour.")

After one joke flubbed, Koy, who was named host after some bigger names reportedly passed, also noted how fast he was thrust into the job.

"Yo, I got the gig 10 days ago. You want a perfect monologue?" said Koy. "I wrote some of these and they're the ones you're laughing at."

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: You're ready for more excitement in your life. You may have gone looking for fun in the wrong places previously and ended up in hot water. If those experiences didn't pan out in the way you hoped.

Taurus: You're finding a new sense of identity, Taurus. You might have had a different opinion of yourself in the past, one that wasn't as favorable as it is today, and now that you're discovering a new confidence.

Gemini: You're in the mood to dive deep. You might spend a lot of time in your head today, pondering your life direction, your spiritual life and health, or your freedom. There are areas in which you're feeling restricted or tied down.

Cancer: You might find yourself leaving your comfort zone today. There's likely a group of people or close friends behind this change, and you may decide to give in to peer pressure -- in a good way!

Leo: A new leadership role may present itself to you. You've most likely been in authority positions in the past, but that doesn't necessarily mean you've taken charge of a group like this before. Perhaps it's made up of people.

Virgo: You're helping others by helping yourself. Your self-confidence is strong right now, where you may typically be more hesitant and guarded. Risk-taking is more your speed these days than usual, but your rolls of the dice are more likely to pay off.

Libra: You're not letting anything bring you down. You may have had struggles in the past that threatened to knock you down from where you were, and your successes and failures have only served to teach.

Scorpio: Boundary-setting might be necessary now. Perhaps you were unaware of an imbalanced power dynamic with someone, and now that you see it clearly, you're beginning to take measures to correct.

Sagittarius: Fear doesn't have to have the last word. Old hang ups may have held you back from taking on a more powerful or vocal position in your career or home life, but now your security and peace of mind.

Capricorn: Some changes are long overdue. Before, you may have felt certain shifts were too risky to your stability, that you might topple over everything if you made a move, but that's not always how life works.

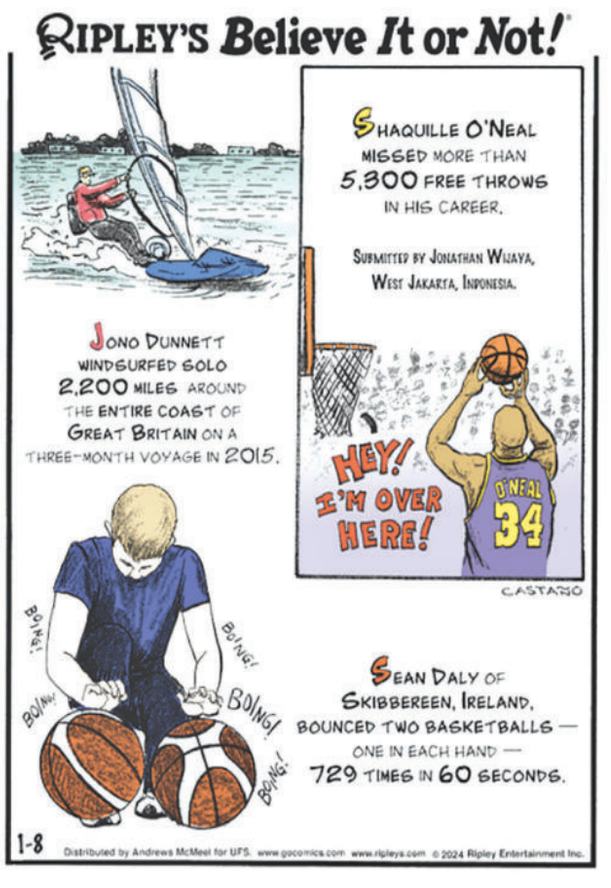
Aquarius: Certain traditions need to be questioned. There's some value in respecting what's always been, but in some instances, a fresh new vision is required, and that's where you come in.

Pisces: It's time to speak up, Pisces! You might think that other people don't want you to join a certain conversation, but it would be worth it for you to say your piece. You're a part of the team just like anyone is.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Arsenal's struggles continue in 2-0 loss to Liverpool in FA Cup



PHOTO: AP

Liverpool's Luis Diaz, center, celebrates with teammates his side's first goal during the English FA Cup soccer match against Arsenal in London.

AP
London, Jan. 8

Three straight losses, an elimination from the FA Cup, and the ominous sight of Manchester City back in form and boosted by the return of Kevin De Bruyne. These are worrying times for Arsenal.

In a heavyweight third-round matchup in the FA Cup, Arsenal's increasingly alarming problems in front of goal were further exposed in a 2-0 loss to Liverpool on Sunday.

An end-to-end contest was settled by two late goals — an own-goal by Arsenal defender Jakub Kiwior in the 80th minute and a fierce strike by Luis Diaz in the fourth minute of stoppage time.

Arsenal has now lost four of its last seven matches in all competitions, including its last three in a row.

"We need to reset," Arsenal manager Mikel Arteta said. "This (upcoming winter) break is good. It has come at a good time." "But at the moment, the thing we have to change, what we have to reset, is up here," he added, pointing to his head.

Even more worrying for Arsenal and Arteta, Man City looks in prime shape heading into the second half of the season, with a 5-0 win over second-tier Huddersfield in the FA Cup notable for the return from injury of De Bruyne after nearly five months out.

De Bruyne hasn't played since sustaining a hamstring injury at Burnley on the opening day of the Premier League season on Aug. 11. The Belgium playmaker came on as a 57th-minute substitute — when City was 2-0 ahead — and provided the cross that fellow replacement Jeremy Doku converted for the final goal in a one-sided match at Etihad Stadium.

Phil Foden scored twice, Julian Alvarez added another and there was an own-goal for the defending champions, who saw defender Manuel Akanji go off injured in the first half.

Wrexham made its Hollywood owners happy by winning 1-0 at Shrewsbury, a local rival from a division higher in English soccer's pyramid, thanks to Tom O'Connor's second-half goal.

Premier League teams West Ham, Nottingham Forest and Luton were all held to draws at home by lower-division opponents.

West Ham failed to hold onto a lead earned by Jarrod Bowen's early goal and drew 1-1 with second-tier Bristol City. There was more bad news for the Hammers, with Brazil midfielder Lucas Paqueta forced off injured in the first half.

Forest had to come from two goals down to draw with third-tier Blackpool 2-2 while another third-tier team, Bolton, held Luton 0-0.

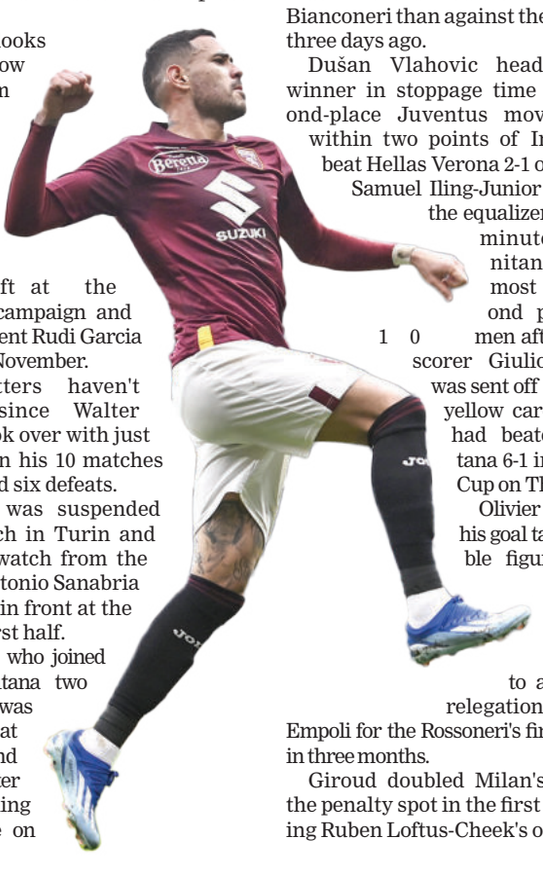
American striker Daryl Dike scored his team's third goal in the 27th minute of second-tier West Bromwich Albion's 4-1 win over fifth-tier Aldershot, his first match since tearing his right Achilles against Stoke last April.

Horror show leaves Napoli 20 points behind leader Inter

AP
Milan, Jan. 8

Barely a year ago, Napoli fans were singing in Turin that their team was going to win the Serie A title following a 4-0 victory. On Sunday, in the same stadium, Napoli fans threw flares onto the field and jeered as the defending champion lost 3-0 at Torino.

A horror show for Napoli — that included defender Pasquale Mazzocchi being sent off just four minutes into his debut — left the team ninth in Serie A, 20 points behind league leader Inter Milan and five below fourth-place Fiorentina.



Napoli looks like a shadow of the team that thrilled in Italy and abroad last season. Title-winning coach Luciano Spalletti left at the end of the campaign and his replacement Rudi Garcia was fired in November.

But matters haven't improved since Walter Mazzarri took over with just three wins in his 10 matches in charge and six defeats.

Mazzarri was suspended for the match in Turin and could only watch from the stands as Antonio Sanabria fired Torino in front at the end of the first half.

Mazzocchi, who joined from Salernitana two days ago, was brought on at halftime and moments later went sliding into a tackle on Valentino Lazaro with a high boot. The referee initially awarded a yellow card but after reviewing the incident on the pitchside monitor changed it to a straight red.

Nikola Vlašic doubled Torino's advantage almost immediately and Alessandro Buongiorno scored the third in the 66th, two minutes after Ivan Ilic hit the post for the home team.

The match was briefly halted shortly afterward as Napoli fans threw flares onto the field. Napoli players went to apologize to the visiting fans after the match.

Juventus recovery

Juventus needed a last-minute goal to win 2-1 at 10-man Salernitana on a much more difficult evening for the Bianconeri than against the same team three days ago.

Dušan Vlahovic headed in the winner in stoppage time to see second-place Juventus move back to within two points of Inter, which beat Hellas Verona 2-1 on Saturday.

Samuel Iling-Junior had scored the equalizer in the 65th minute. Salernitana played most of the second period with 10 men after first-half scorer Giulio Maggiore was sent off for a second yellow card. Juventus had beaten Salernitana 6-1 in the Italian Cup on Thursday.

Olivier Giroud took his goal tally into double figures for the 14th season in a row as he helped AC Milan to a 3-0 win at relegation-threatened Empoli for the Rossoneri's first away win in three months.

Giroud doubled Milan's lead from the penalty spot in the first half following Ruben Loftus-Cheek's opener.

SNIPPETS

AFP, Army march into semis

Surkhet (TRN): The defending champions Nepal APF Club defeated Nepal Police Club by 25-17, 25-15, 22-25, and 25-20 in the 34th National Volleyball Tournament held in Surkhet on Monday. With three consecutive victories, APF secured the top position in the Group A table. To clinch the group winner's title, APF needs to win over Bagmati Province on Tuesday. If Police win over Koshi Province on Tuesday, they will advance to the last four as runners-up. In another match held on Monday, Tribhuvan Army Club beat Gandaki Province in a straight set of 31-29, 25-21, and 25-21, securing nine points to top the Group B standings. Gandaki Province has six points.

Youth football friendly on Feb. 10

Kathmandu (TRN): Nepal Youth Football is all set to play a friendly match against Qinghai Youth Football Team of China on February 10 at Dasharath Stadium, All Nepal Football Association (ANFA) confirmed on Monday. The friendly is being organized by the Embassy of the People's Republic of China in Nepal, National Sports Council and Nepal Tourism Board. ANFA and Nepal Overseas Chinese Association are the co-organizers of the friendly. According to ANFA, the match will be played at 3 PM and various shows from Nepal and China in the opening ceremony and half time interval of the friendly.

Kerr sustains ACL injury

London (AP): Australia striker Sam Kerr sustained an anterior cruciate ligament injury during a warm-weather training camp with Chelsea women's team in Morocco, the English club said Sunday. Kerr, who has scored 99 goals in 128 games for Chelsea, will be assessed by a specialist before beginning a lengthy period of rehabilitation. Australian media reported Kerr could be out for up to nine months.

Kerr's absence is a huge blow for Chelsea, which is top of the Women's Super League — three points clear of Manchester City and Arsenal. "Everyone at Chelsea would like to wish Sam the very best for her recovery," a team statement read.

Barcelona reach round of 16

AP
Madrid, Jan. 8

Barcelona struggled more than expected in a 3-2 win over fourth-division club Barbastro in the third round of the Copa del Rey on Sunday.

It was another lackluster performance for Barcelona, but enough to send the Catalan club into the round of 16.

"We suffered more than necessary," Barcelona coach Xavi Hernández said. "It's a game in which you can score several goals, but when you don't, you end up suffering more than expected."

Barcelona was coming off hard-fought wins against last-place Almeria and midtable Las Palmas in the Spanish league. It hadn't won in three straight games before that in all competitions.

Fermín López opened the scoring for Barcelona with a low shot from near the penalty spot after a cross by Raphinha in the 18th minute, and the Brazil forward added to the lead himself from close range in the 51st.

The hosts pulled closer with a goal by Adriá de Mesa off a corner in the 60th before Robert Lewandowski came off the bench to add Barcelona's third by converting an 88th-minute penalty kick. Marc Prat Serrano scored for Barbastro again three minutes into stoppage time.

Valencia needed extra time to win 2-1 and escape an upset against 10-man Cartagena, the last-place team in Spain's second division.

Sergi Canós equalized in the 73rd after the hosts had taken the lead through Alfredo Ortuño four minutes into the match. José Luis Gayà netted the winner in the first half of extra time.

Cartagena played a man down after midfielder Iván Calero was sent off in first-half stoppage time.

Other topflight clubs to beat lower-division teams on Sunday included Athletic Bilbao, Celta Vigo, Mallorca, Sevilla, Real Sociedad and Osasuna.

Bilbao cruised past Eibar 3-0, Celta won 4-2 against Amorebieta, Mallorca beat Burgos 3-0, Sevilla won 2-1 at Racing Ferrol, Sociedad topped Malaga 1-0 and Osasuna defeated Castellon 1-0.

Mario Zagallo buried as Brazil pays its last respects to World Cup great

AP
Rio De Janeiro, Jan. 8



Fans, players and coaches paid their last respects in Brazil to Mario Zagallo on Sunday, as the first person to win the World Cup both as a player and a manager was buried at a Rio de Janeiro cemetery.

Zagallo was seen by many as the embodiment of the Brazilian national team, whose flair and skills gained a global following, with a large banner reading "Zagallo eternal" at the Brazilian soccer confederation (CBF) headquarters. Tributes on Sunday began with a public wake and then a private funeral, attended by friends and family, at the CBF museum.

His casket was later transported on top of a firetruck through Rio on a sunny Sunday afternoon. It was covered in the flags of world soccer governing body FIFA, South American soccer body CONMEBOL, and the CBF.

Upon arrival at the Sao Joao Batista cemetery, only Brazil's national flag was on the casket as dozens of fans silently joined family members and former players like soccer great Cafu to bid Zagallo farewell.

"I owe my career in the national team to him," said former player Zinho, who tearfully kissed Zagallo's forehead in an open casket during the wake. "I recently wanted to visit him, he was not in good shape, but still called me to chat later. I lost a father."

Zagallo won two World Cups as a player (1958 and '62), one as a coach (with the still revered team of 1970) and another as an assistant coach (1994) for Brazil.

He died late on Friday at age 92 of multiple-organ failure. Local media reported he was hospitalized after Christmas.

A life-size statue of the soccer legend was close to his casket during the wake. Zagallo saw the unveiling of the statue in a wheelchair in October 2022. Replicas of all five World Cup trophies Brazil has won were placed in front of Zagallo's casket. His sons received miniature versions of them.

"I can only thank people all over the world for all the love they are giving to my father," said Paulo Zagallo. "He was lucid until the end. It was God's will to allow him to rest so he didn't suffer so much."

Fans like Jair Almeida Alves, 56, applauded as they passed by Zagallo's casket. Wearing a Botafogo shirt, one of Zagallo's clubs as player and coach, Alves said he saw him as a national hero.

"He is the embodiment of what it is to be proud about being Brazilian. Only later in his life people understood Zagallo, how important he was for our soccer, for our identity," Alves said. "This is a celebration of his life, he lived a great life, made us happy and is now in the history books."

Europe-based Vinicius Junior, Richarlison and Casemiro have been among current Brazil players to pay tribute. Neymar, Brazil's all-time top goal scorer, has reportedly made no public comment so far.

Zagallo was also the last living member of Brazil's starting team in its first championship victory in the tournament in 1958.

He played a role in nearly every major chapter in Brazilian soccer history, from its first World Cup title in 1958 to the tournament it hosted in 2014. Former Brazil coach Tite visited him to hear his advice before taking the team to the 2018 and 2022 World Cups.

Zagallo coached Brazil in the 1970, 1974 and 1998 World Cups, winning the first of those. He was the team's assistant coach in the 1994 title-winning campaign.

Brazil soccer great Ronaldo, the 1994 and 2002 World Cup winner, was among many to send wreaths.

"Zagallo, your era is eternal," his message said. "Thanks for everything you taught me. Rest in peace. I love you."

Brazil's President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva declared three days of national mourning on Saturday.

WEATHER

Tuesday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:25 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Tuesday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province, Gandaki Province and Karnali Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 17-19 Rain Probability: 0%

Monday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	15.7	2.9	0.0
Dipayal	23.6	2.8	0.0
Dhangadi	17.7	10.2	0.0
Birendranagar	22.0	5.9	0.0
Nepalgunj	19.5	11.6	0.0
Jumla	14.5	-5.4	0.0
Ghorahi	21.6	7.7	0.0
Pokhara	20.6	8.6	0.0
Bhairahawa	15.8	11.5	0.0
Simara	20.3	9.0	0.0
Kathmandu	17.8	4.2	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.6	7.2	0.0
Taplejung	16.5	5.2	0.0
Dhankuta	22.3	8.4	0.0
Biratnagar	23.2	10.5	0.0
Jomsom	10.1	-4.5	0.0*
Dharan	24.5	12.6	0.0*
Lumle	15.2	5.2	0.0*
Janakpur	23.0	14.4	0.0*
Jiri	15.2	-0.1	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 9, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.73	Rs. 133.33
Euro	1	Rs. 145.25	Rs. 145.90
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.72	Rs. 169.48
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.98	Rs. 156.68
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 88.81	Rs. 89.21
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.18	Rs. 99.63
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.72	Rs.100.17
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.19	Rs. 9.23
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.54	Rs. 18.62
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.39	Rs. 35.55
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.42	Rs. 36.58
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.79	Rs. 3.80
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.14	Rs. 36.30
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.54	Rs. 28.67
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.07	Rs. 10.11
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.90	Rs. 12.96
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.47	Rs. 19.56
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.00	Rs. 17.08
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.74	Rs. 433.69
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.06	Rs. 353.65

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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